

Photoshop: From First Win to Finished Work

The full teaching manual for the eight-session course (one 3-hour session per module). Timing, live-demo scripts, the beginner mistakes to pre-empt, lab facilitation, and checks for understanding — for all eight modules.

8 modules • 22 lessons

8 sessions × 3 h • 24 h with labs & breaks

Instructor copy • not for students

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Module 0: Your First Win

How to run Session 1: welcome the room, orient everyone to how this course works, get every copy of Photoshop working, and then deliver the single lesson that opens the course. Learners open a photo, straighten and crop it, brighten it with one adjustment layer, and export a share-ready JPEG, then do it again on their own photo. Protect the first-day energy: everyone leaves with a finished image.

1 lesson

3 hrs session

Lesson L01

Level Absolute beginner

Maps to Session 1

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

- The course runs as **8 sessions × 3 hours**, one module per session. Session 1 = Module 0 (this guide), Session 2 = Module 1, and so on through Session 8 = Module 7 (Capstone).
- Every lesson runs the same rhythm: **Frame → Demo → Guided build → Solo variation → Check**. The lessons are built this way on purpose (a guided build, then a "Now You" repeat with a twist), so follow their order.
- **Demo everything live on the projector.** Beginners mirror your screen click for click. Say the menu path out loud every time ("File, Save As..."), and say both shortcuts: **Ctr**l on Windows, **⌘** on Mac.
- **Teal** = hands-on, **amber** = watch-outs. "**Say:**" lines in the demo scripts are suggested wording; make them your own.
- Quiz items live in the participant workbook's **Self-check** boxes; answers are summarized here and explained in full in the Answer Key.

THE #1 RISK OF SESSION 1: INSTALL AND SIGN-IN DRIFT

Photoshop is a Creative Cloud app. A learner who arrives with an expired trial, an unsigned-in account, or a half-finished download can lose the whole morning. Send a **pre-class email** (install Photoshop, sign in, launch it once, bring 4–5 of your own photos) and use the setup-check block to catch the rest. Never freeze the room to fix one laptop: pair that learner with a neighbor and keep moving.

BEFORE SESSION 1

- ☐ Every machine has **Photoshop 2025 or later**, signed in and launched once. (The course home page recommends the current version; the Remove tool used in Module 1 needs Photoshop 2023 v24.5 or later.)
- ☐ Copy `labs/module-0/practice/` to each machine (or a shared drive). These synthetic files are safe to

redistribute. **Do not** hand out the course site's `images/` folder: it is licensed stock and not redistributable.

- ◆ ☐ Learners bring **4–5 photos of their own** on the laptop, not only on a phone (see the list in `labs/module-0/README.md`). For today they need at least one that's a little dark or crooked and one that's too bright.
- ◆ ☐ On the projector machine: reset the workspace (**Window ► Workspace ► Reset Essentials**) so your screen matches a fresh install, and raise the interface size if the room is large.
- ◆ ☐ Open the course site in a browser tab: the home page (for orientation), `recipes.html`, and `lesson_01.html` (for the before/after slider).
- ◆ ☐ A way to share results: a shared folder, a projector-connected laptop that can open learners' JPEGs, or a gallery walk around the room.

SESSION 1 AGENDA (3 HOURS)

CLOCK	SEGMENT	MIN	NOTES
0:00–0:15	Welcome & introductions	15	Name, what you shoot or make, one image you'd love to be able to create.
0:15–0:35	Course orientation	20	Project-driven path, the Recipes library, journaling, growth mindset.
0:35–0:55	Setup check + workspace tour & reset	20	Everyone opens <code>l01-tilted-horizon.jpg</code> ; four neighborhoods; reset workspace.
0:55–1:45	L01 Fix & Export One Photo: demo + guided lab + self-check	50	Lesson plan below. Everyone exports <code>myphoto-final.jpg</code> .
1:45–2:00	Break	15	Leave the 5-step recipe card on the projector.
2:00–2:35	Independent pass on your own photo	35	The lesson's "Now You" solo variation, on a learner photo. You coach; you don't demo.
2:35–2:50	Share-out	15	Before/after eyeball toggles, 30–45 seconds each (or a gallery walk).
2:50–3:00	First journal entry + wrap-up	10	Journal (7 min), then "Before the next lesson" and a Session 2 preview (3 min).
Total		180	If you run long, shorten the share-out, never the journal.

Session 1 is one story: **meet the course → get the tools working → finish one photo together → finish another one alone → show it off → write down why you're here**. The lesson page estimates 25 minutes for a solo learner; in a room, with a demo before each step and a second independent pass, it fills the session.

0:00

Welcome & Introductions

15 min

- 1 **Your story (3m).** Introduce yourself and why you love this tool. Keep it short and human.
- 2 **Round of names (10m).** Each learner: name, what they shoot or make, and *one image they'd love to be able to create*. Jot these down: they are gold for examples later in the course and for the Capstone in Session 8.
- 3 **Housekeeping (2m).** Break time, restrooms, Wi-Fi, where files are saved, how to ask for help (hand up, or a sticky note on the laptop lid).

◆ TALKING POINTS & LIVE-DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 **Project-driven, not a tool tour (5m).** Show the course home page. **Say:** "Most software courses march you through menus: here's the Brush tool, here's a dialog box you'll forget by lunch. This one doesn't. Every module ends in a finished deliverable, and you learn each skill at the moment the project needs it." Walk the path: **Module 0** First Win, **1** Foundations (a messy photo cleaned up), **2** Light & Color, **3** Retouching, **4** Compositing, **5** Design & Type (a poster), **6** AI & Speed, **7** Capstone (a self-directed portfolio piece, presented). One module per session.
- 2 **It spirals (3m).** Name the four big ideas that keep coming back, each time deeper: **non-destructive editing**, the **layer stack**, **masks as grayscale**, and **selections**. **Say:** "You don't finish layers today and move on. You'll keep meeting them until they're second nature."
- 3 **The Recipes library (4m).** Open **recipes.html**. Type "horizon" in the filter box and show the "Straighten a crooked horizon" card. **Say:** "Recipes are short, standalone how-tos you can use in any order, each linked to the lesson that teaches the why. They're the reason you don't have to memorize everything." Every lesson also ends with its own recipe card; the workbook reprints them.
- 4 **Journaling (4m).** Show the workbook's Journal box. Five things after every lesson: **key concepts · techniques that clicked · questions or confusion · ideas to try · progress and feelings**. **Say:** "Your first entry today is about why you're here. At the Capstone you'll read it again, and you'll be amazed how far you've come."
- 5 **Growth mindset (4m).** **Say:** "If Photoshop feels like 'too much,' that feeling is normal, and temporary. You are not going to learn all of Photoshop. Nobody has. You're going to learn the handful of ideas it's built on, and then use them. Add the word *yet* to anything that feels hard today." Set the norm: mistakes are expected, and non-destructive editing means almost nothing you do in this course is permanent.

◆ SEQUENCE

- 1 **Launch and open (7m).** Everyone launches Photoshop and opens `l01-tilted-horizon.jpg` with **File ► Open**. Hands up when the photo is on screen. Anyone stuck (sign-in prompt, trial expired, can't find the file) gets paired with a neighbor right away while you or a helper sorts it out.
- 2 **Reset the workspace (3m).** **Window ► Workspace ► Reset Essentials.** Say: "Now all our screens match. If your panels ever go missing or get scrambled, this is the fix."
- 3 **The four neighborhoods (7m).** Point at each and have learners point at theirs: **Tools** (left edge: where we grab the Crop tool), **Options bar** (along the top: settings for whatever tool is selected), **Canvas** (the big middle: your photo), **Layers panel** (bottom-right: the layer stack lives here). Say: "Yours has a thousand more buttons. Ignore them today." Show the rescue: **Window ► Layers** or F7 if the Layers panel is missing. Hover a tool to show its name and shortcut letter.
- 4 **Close without saving (3m).** Close the photo (don't save). Say: "We'll open it again properly in a minute, and the very first thing we'll do is protect the original."

◆ WATCH-OUTS

- ◆ **Photo only on the phone.** Learners who didn't copy photos to the laptop use the practice files for now and AirDrop, email, or cloud-sync their own photos during the guided lab, ready for the independent pass after the break.
- ◆ **Home screen confusion.** Photoshop may open to a Home screen instead of an empty workspace. **File ► Open** works from there too.

MODULE AT A GLANCE

LESSON	TOPIC	TIME	LEARNERS LEAVE ABLE TO...
L01	Fix & Export One Photo	50m + 35m	Run the whole loop: Open → Save .psd → Crop → Adjust → Save → Export JPG, and say what "non-destructive" means

L01

Fix & Export One Photo

50 min + 35 min independent

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Open a photo and straighten & crop it with the Crop tool
- ◆ Improve its brightness and contrast with a Brightness/Contrast adjustment layer
- ◆ Explain, in one sentence, what "non-destructive editing" means and why it matters
- ◆ Export a finished JPEG without ever altering the original file

◆ TIMING (0:55-1:45)

4m	The 20-minute promise: show the lesson's before/after slider
8m	One idea: tracing paper (layers, adjustment layers, non-destructive)
30m	Guided build, Steps 1-4 (demo a step, room does it, next step) + checklist
8m	Self-check (workbook Q1-Q6), answers aloud

◆ TEACHING SEQUENCE & LIVE-DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 **Open with the payoff (4m).** Put `Lesson_01.html` on the projector and drag the before/after handle. **Say:** "You don't need to understand everything today. You need to finish one photo. Understanding grows out of finishing, not the other way around."
- 2 **Tracing paper (8m).** Hold a sheet of paper over a printed photo if you have one. **Say:** "Instead of drawing on the photo with a marker, we lay tracing paper over it. Brighter? One sheet. Warmer? Another sheet. Hate it? Peel it off. The photo underneath is never touched." Name the terms: those sheets are **layers**; sheets that only carry an instruction ("make everything under me brighter") are **adjustment layers**; working this way is **non-destructive editing**. **Say:** "Every professional retoucher works this way. It's not a beginner shortcut you'll outgrow; it's the real workflow, so you never have to unlearn a bad habit."
- 3 **Step 1: Open & save a working file (5m).** Click **File ► Open**, choose `l01-tilted-horizon.jpg`. Immediately **File ► Save As**, format **Photoshop (.psd)**, name `myphoto-working.psd`. If Photoshop asks where to save, click **Save on your computer**. **Say:** "The .psd remembers layers. The original JPEG stays untouched on disk. That's tracing paper applied to the file itself."
- 4 **Step 2: Straighten & crop (8m).** Press C. Drag a corner inward to trim distracting edges (on the practice file, crop out the dark blob in the bottom-left corner). Then move the cursor just outside a corner until it becomes a **bent arrow** and drag to rotate until the grid lines match the horizon. Press

Enter (Return). **Say:** "Straightening is just rotating the grid until it agrees with a line that should be level." Walk the room before moving on: this step spreads people out.

- 5 **Step 3: One adjustment layer (9m).** At the bottom of the Layers panel click the half-black/half-white circle (●) and choose **Brightness/Contrast**. Nudge **Brightness** up until the shadows open up; nudge **Contrast** up a little for punch. Point at the Layers panel: a new sheet sits above the photo. Then the **magic moment**: click the eyeball next to the adjustment layer off and on. **Say:** "The whole effect vanishes and comes back. Proof we changed nothing in the photo itself." Pause until every learner has clicked their own eyeball.
- 6 **Step 4: Save, then export (6m).** **File ► Save** (Ct r l / ⌘ + S) so the .psd keeps the adjustment layer. Then **File ► Export ► Export As...**, format **JPG**, quality around **80%**, **Export**, name `myphoto-final.jpg`. **Say:** "Two files now: the layered .psd is your editable master, the flat .jpg is the copy you share. Never post the .psd. Never edit on the .jpg."
- 7 **Checklist (2m).** Read the lesson's five-item Project Completion Checklist aloud; hands up for "all five." **Say:** "You just completed the entire Photoshop loop. Take the win."
- 8 **Self-check (8m).** Learners answer workbook Q1–Q6 alone (4m), then you reveal answers and ask one volunteer to explain each "why."

◆ LAB: INDEPENDENT PASS ON YOUR OWN PHOTO (2:00–2:35)

This is the lesson's "Now You" solo variation, done on a **learner's own photo**. Repeat the whole loop without a demo. Suggested twist from the lesson: choose a photo that's **too bright**, lower Brightness a touch, then add a **second** adjustment layer (● ► **Vibrance**, push Vibrance up gently), and export. Compare side by side with the original. Anyone without a suitable photo uses `101-too-bright.jpg`. Early finishers run the recipe on a third photo. Details in `labs/module-0/README.md`.

Your role: coach, don't drive. When someone asks "how do I...?", point to the recipe card in their workbook first. Name files with the learner's own subject (e.g. `beach-working.psd`, `beach-final.jpg`).

Circulate for: a working .psd saved *before* editing; two adjustment layers visible in the Layers panel (not one layer edited twice); an exported .jpg with a new name so the original isn't overwritten.

Definition of done: every learner has two finished loops (practice file + own photo), each with a .psd containing at least one adjustment layer and an exported .jpg, and can toggle the eyeball to show the before/after.

◆ SHARE-OUT (2:35–2:50)

Each learner (or volunteers, in a large room) shows their own-photo .psd for 30–45 seconds: toggle the adjustment layers' eyeballs for the before/after and say **one** choice they made ("I lowered brightness because the sky was blown out"). Alternative: a gallery walk with laptops open to the .psd. Celebrate subtle edits out loud: the lesson's FAQ is clear that a subtle, tasteful edit done non-destructively is a complete success.

◆ BEGINNER MISTAKES TO PRE-EMPT

- ◆ **Skipping Save As .psd.** Without a working .psd it's easy to save changes back over the original JPEG, a format that can't store layers, so the edit gets baked in for good. Make Save As the very first click, every time, and say why.
- ◆ **Saving to the cloud by accident.** The first Save As may offer cloud documents. Tell the room to click **Save on your computer** so they can find the file afterward.
- ◆ **Crop tool remembers the last ratio.** If the crop box snaps to a square or a fixed shape, open the ratio menu in the options bar and click **Clear** so the box drags freely.
- ◆ **Rotating by dragging inside the box.** Dragging inside moves the image; rotating only happens with the **bent arrow** just *outside* a corner. Demo the cursor change slowly.
- ◆ **Forgetting to commit the crop.** Nothing else works while the crop is pending. Press Enter/Return (or click the check mark in the options bar).
- ◆ **Pushing Brightness to the max.** Say "nudge." A subtle edit is a complete success.
- ◆ **Export confusion.** Export As writes a *new* file. If someone exports over their original (same name, same folder), they've lost it. Always use a **-final** name.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING: SELF-CHECK + JOURNAL

Answers: **Q1 B)** Changes live on layers above the photo, so the original pixels are never altered; **Q2 B)** A .psd keeps your layers, and the original stays untouched; **Q3 A)** Bent arrow just outside a corner, rotate to match the horizon; **Q4 C)** The edit lives on the adjustment layer, not in the photo; **Q5 B)** Save writes the layered .psd, Export makes a flat share-ready copy; **Q6 A)** Window ► Layers (or F7). Full explanations in the Answer Key.

First journal entry (2:50–2:57): *Why do you want to learn Photoshop, and what's one image you dream of being able to make?* Remind the room of the five journal headings and that you'll come back to this entry at the Capstone (Session 8). Paper learners use the workbook's Journal box.

Quick verbal check (during the share-out): "Explain non-destructive editing in one sentence." Listen for "the original is never changed."

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

Fast finishers: the lesson's "Going further": reorder the two adjustment layers by dragging one above the other and see whether the result changes. Then try the **Straighten** button in the Crop options bar (drag a line along what should be level) as a second way to straighten, and run the recipe on a third photo. Point them at the Recipes library's "Crop to an exact size or ratio" card.

Struggling learners: for the independent pass, drop the Vibrance twist and repeat Steps 1–4 exactly, with the workbook's recipe card beside them. Pair them with a finisher who "drives" only by pointing, never by taking the mouse. The only must-haves today are an exported JPEG and one eyeball toggle.

CLOSING THE SESSION

WRAP-UP (2:57–3:00)

Recap the loop on the board: **Open → Save .psd → Crop → Adjust → Save → Export JPG**. Golden rule: edits live on adjustment layers, never on the photo. Assign the lesson's "Before the next lesson": keep your .psd, run the 5-step recipe on two more photos until it feels automatic, finish your journal entry. Ask learners to bring photos for Session 2: a landscape with a pale sky, a photo with one clear subject (person, pet, or product), and a photo with dust, a blemish, or a distracting object. Preview Session 2 (Module 1): "Today's adjustment changed the whole photo. The best edits are local: brighten *this*, calm down *that*. Next time we meet the tool for 'only here, not there': the mask."

Module 1: Foundations

How to teach the three lessons that turn a first win into a working method: reading the layer stack, targeting an edit with a mask (black hides, white reveals), letting Photoshop find edges and baking the selection into a mask, and cleaning up a photo without destroying a pixel. This is the conceptual core of the whole course.

3 lessons

3 hrs session

Lessons L02-L04

Level Beginner

Maps to Session 2

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

- Same rhythm as Module 0: **Frame** → **Demo** → **Guided build** → **Solo variation** → **Check**. Every lesson ends with a recipe card, a checklist, and a journal prompt; use them as your closers.
- Demo live, step by step.** Demo one step, let the room do it, then move on. Name every click, and say both shortcut forms (Alt/⌘, Ctrl/⌘).
- Teal** = hands-on, **amber** = watch-outs. In this module the watch-outs are mostly "wrong thing selected" problems: the wrong layer, the wrong thumbnail, the wrong Sample setting. Pre-empting them saves the most time.

THE #1 RISK OF MODULE 1: "IT'S NOT DOING ANYTHING"

Almost every stuck learner in this module has the **wrong thing selected**: the photo layer instead of the mask, an empty layer with Sample All Layers unchecked, a Clone Stamp still on "Current Layer." Teach the room to diagnose before they click: "**Which layer is highlighted? Which thumbnail has the border? What does the options bar say?**" Write those three questions on the board.

BEFORE SESSION 2

- ☐ Copy `labs/module-1/practice/` to each machine (or a shared drive). As always, never hand out the course site's licensed `images/` folder.
- ☐ Remind learners (in the Session 1 wrap-up or by email) to bring: a **landscape with a pale, washed-out sky**; a photo with **one clear subject** (person, pet, or product; hair or fur for the stretch goal); a photo with **dust, a blemish, or a distracting object**. Details in `labs/module-1/README.md`.
- ☐ Check every machine is on Photoshop 2023 v24.5 or later (Help ► About Photoshop on Windows, Photoshop ► About Photoshop on Mac) so the **Remove tool** is there for L04.

- ◆ ☐ Open [lesson_02.html](#), [lesson_03.html](#), and [lesson_04.html](#) in browser tabs for the before/after sliders.

SESSION 2 AGENDA (3 HOURS)

CLOCK	SEGMENT	MIN	NOTES
0:00–0:10	Warm-up: recall the Module 0 loop	10	Room recites Open → Save .psd → Crop → Adjust → Save → Export. Two volunteers show a homework photo (eyeball toggle).
0:10–1:00	L02 The Layer Stack & Your First Mask	50	Build: rescue the sky.
1:00–1:50	L03 Selections That Hold Up	50	Build: cut out a subject, new background.
1:50–2:05	Break	15	Leave the L03 checklist on the projector for stragglers.
2:05–2:55	L04 Cleaning Up: Spots, Distractions & Edges	50	Build: clean and export (the Module 1 deliverable). Solo variation starts here, finishes at home.
2:55–3:00	Wrap-up & exit ticket	5	Recap the arc, assign homework, preview Session 3.
Total		180	Add a one-minute stand-and-stretch midway through L02; it comes out of demo time, not lab time.

The lesson pages estimate 45 + 50 + 50 minutes for a solo learner, which matches the room once the demos run alongside the builds. If you run long, protect the L04 guided build (it's the Module 1 deliverable) and move solo variations to homework.

MODULE AT A GLANCE

LESSON	TOPIC	TIME	LEARNERS LEAVE ABLE TO...
L02	The Layer Stack & Your First Mask	50m	Read a stack and paint a mask so an adjustment hits only part of a photo
L03	Selections That Hold Up	50m	Select a subject, refine the edge in Select & Mask, and output to a layer mask
L04	Cleaning Up: Spots, Distractions & Edges	50m	Heal, remove, and clone on a separate layer, then export a clean photo

The module is one story: **paint a stencil by hand → let Photoshop draw the stencil → cover bad pixels with good ones on a separate sheet**. The through-line is the Module 0 golden rule: never touch the original pixels.

L02

The Layer Stack & Your First Mask

50 min

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Read a layer stack: what's on top wins, and why order matters
- ◆ Explain a mask in one sentence: black hides, white reveals, gray partly reveals
- ◆ Paint on a layer mask to apply an adjustment to only part of a photo
- ◆ Recover from mistakes by painting the mask back: no undo panic required

◆ TIMING

3m	The problem: one edit, two regions (lesson slider)
4m	Mental model 1: the stack of glass
6m	Mental model 2: a mask is a stencil
3m	Reading the Layers panel: two thumbnails
20m	Guided build: rescue the sky (Steps 1–4)
7m	Now You: spotlight a subject
7m	Self-check, recipe card, journal

◆ TEACHING SEQUENCE & LIVE-DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 The problem (3m).** Show the L02 slider. **Say:** "To get detail in the land, the camera blew the sky out. Darken everything and the land goes muddy. We want to darken the sky *only*. Notice the hills are identical on both sides."
- 2 Stack of glass (4m).** Upgrade the Module 0 metaphor. **Say:** "Layers are sheets of glass in a frame, and you look straight down. Paint on a higher sheet covers what's below; clear glass lets the lower sheets show." Write the two rules: **higher layers win where they're opaque** and **order is meaning**.
- 3 A mask is a stencil (6m).** Every adjustment layer comes with a **layer mask**, a grayscale card that decides, pixel by pixel, how much of the effect gets through. Have the whole room say the sentence aloud: **"Black hides. White reveals. Gray does a bit of both."** Sketch a card that's white at the top, black at the bottom, gray between. Then the superpower: **Say:** "Painted over something by accident? Switch to the opposite color and paint it back. Nothing is ever destroyed. That's why pros mask instead of erase."

- 4 **Two thumbnails (3m).** Point at an adjustment layer: the effect (●) and the mask (white card). **Say:** "Before you paint, click the mask thumbnail so it gets a highlighted border. On an adjustment layer your brush lands on the mask anyway, but on a pixel layer with a mask, painting with the image thumbnail selected paints the photo itself. Build the habit now."
- 5 **Step 1 (2m).** Open `102-washed-sky.jpg` (or a learner landscape). **File ► Save As ►** `sky-rescue-working.psd`. **Say:** "You know the rhythm: protect the original first."
- 6 **Step 2 (3m).** ● ► **Brightness/Contrast.** Pull Brightness **down** until the sky looks rich. **Say:** "Ignore the land going too dark. The mask will fix that. Right now the mask is all white, all revealed, so the darkening hits everything."
- 7 **Step 3 (8m).** Click the mask thumbnail. Press D (default colors), then X so black is the foreground. **Edit ► Fill..., Contents: Black,** or press `Alt/⌘ + Backspace/Delete`. The darkening vanishes. **Say:** "Not `Ctrl/⌘ + Backspace`: that fills with the *background* color, which is white, so nothing happens." Press B, X for white, pick a big soft brush (] to enlarge), and paint over the sky. **Say:** "Watch the mask thumbnail: a white sky-shape is growing on the black card. That's your stencil." Deliberately paint onto a hill, then press X and paint it away."
- 8 **Step 4 (5m).** Lower brush opacity to about 30% (with the Brush active, pressing 3 sets 30%) and gently blend along the horizon. **Say:** "This is painting gray: a partial reveal." Toggle the eyeball for the before/after, **File ► Save**, then **File ► Export ► Export As ► JPG 80% →** `sky-rescue-final.jpg`.

◆ LAB: RESCUE THE SKY, THEN NOW YOU

Guided build on `102-washed-sky.jpg`; solo variation on `102-spotlight-object.jpg` or a learner's portrait/object photo: brighten with a Brightness/Contrast layer, fill the mask black, paint white only over the subject; then a second, darkening layer masked to the background. Details in `labs/module-1/README.md`.

Circulate for: the mask thumbnail (not the photo) highlighted; a black mask with a white sky-shape in the thumbnail; a soft horizon, not a hard line.

Definition of done: the lesson's five-item checklist: one Brightness/Contrast layer above the photo, mask black over the land and white over the sky, a richer sky with untouched land, a soft transition, .psd saved and JPG exported.

◆ BEGINNER MISTAKES TO PRE-EMPT

- ◆ **Painting on the photo.** If the Background (photo) layer is highlighted, the brush paints real white or black paint onto the picture. Symptom: white streaks in the sky. Fix: undo, click the mask thumbnail on the adjustment layer, paint again.
- ◆ **Fill did nothing.** They used `Ctrl/⌘ + Backspace` (background color = white). Use `Alt/⌘ + Backspace` with black foreground, or **Edit ► Fill ► Black**.
- ◆ **Colors aren't pure black and white.** A previous color pick left a tinted foreground, so the reveal is partial everywhere. Press D to reset.

- ◆ **Opacity left at 30%.** After softening the seam, the next strokes barely reveal anything. Press 0 for 100% (with the Brush active).
- ◆ **Hard, obvious edge.** The brush Hardness is high. Right-click the canvas and lower Hardness, then paint the seam at low opacity.
- ◆ **Undo panic.** Learners hammer `Ctrl/⌘ + Z` after every slip. Redirect: "Press X and paint it back."

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING: SELF-CHECK + JOURNAL

Answers: **Q1** B) It covers what's below it; **Q2** A) The adjustment is hidden there; **Q3** C) `Ctrl/⌘ + Backspace` fills with the background color (white); **Q4** B) Press X and paint black over the mistake; **Q5** A) Click the mask thumbnail; **Q6** C) Lower brush Hardness and paint the seam at low opacity. Full set in the Answer Key.

Journal (3 min, finish at home if needed): *Describe, in your own words and without looking, what happens when you paint black on a mask versus white. If you can teach it to an imaginary friend, you own it.* Pair-share option: learners explain it to a neighbor first, then write.

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

Fast finishers: the lesson's "Going further": select the mask thumbnail and press `Ctrl/⌘ + I` to invert it and watch the reveal flip. Then try the opposite workflow from the FAQ: start with a white mask and paint black to subtract, and decide which needs less painting for this shot. `Alt/⌥`-clicking the mask thumbnail shows the mask itself on the canvas (click again to return), a great way to inspect a seam.

Struggling learners: skip Step 4's seam softening at first; get a black mask with a white sky first. Hand them the recipe card and the three diagnosis questions. If the black/white logic won't stick, have them paint black and white stripes on the mask and toggle the eyeball: seeing the effect switch on and off stripe by stripe usually makes it click.

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Explain the difference between a selection (a temporary request) and a mask (the saved answer)
- ◆ Select a subject automatically with Select Subject and the Object Selection tool
- ◆ Rescue tricky edges (hair, fur, motion) in the Select & Mask workspace
- ◆ Output a selection to a layer mask so the cutout stays non-destructive and re-editable

◆ TIMING

3m	The goal: a believable cutout (lesson slider)
5m	Mental model: request vs. answer
6m	The selection toolkit tour
24m	Guided build: Steps 1–4 (4 + 6 + 10 + 4)
6m	Now You: a wispy subject (finish during the break or at home)
6m	Self-check, recipe card, journal

◆ TEACHING SEQUENCE & LIVE-DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 **The goal (3m).** Show the L03 slider. **Say:** "Last lesson we painted a mask by hand. Perfect for a sky, hopeless for hair or the crisp edge of a bottle. Today Photoshop finds the edge for us."
- 2 **Request vs. answer (5m).** Make a quick selection and point at the **marching ants**. **Say:** "This outline is temporary. It's me pointing and saying 'these pixels, please.' Click elsewhere and it's gone. A mask is that request written down permanently: inside the ants becomes white, outside becomes black." Then the warning: **Say:** "Beginners chase a perfect selection and then delete the background, destroying pixels forever. Pros make a good-enough selection, turn it into a mask, and refine the mask forever after."
- 3 **Toolkit (6m).** Walk the lesson's table: **Select Subject** (one click, AI guesses the main subject: your best first click), **Object Selection** (draw a loose box, it snaps to the object inside), **Quick Selection** (paint and it grows to matching edges), **Select & Mask** (a whole room for refining edges). **Say:** "Match the tool to the subject."
- 4 **Step 1 (4m).** Open `l03-subject-busy-bg.jpg`, **Save As** `cutout-working.psd`. **Select► Subject.** **Say:** "It won't be perfect. That's expected and fine." (If it grabs the wrong thing on this

synthetic file, switch to the Object Selection tool and draw a box around the subject: that's also a lesson FAQ.)

- 5 **Step 2 (6m).** Press **W** for Quick Selection (**Shift + W** cycles if Object Selection or Magic Wand appears). Paint over missed subject to add; hold **Alt/⌘** and paint over included background to subtract. **Say:** "Get the big shape right. The fiddly edges have their own room."
- 6 **Step 3 (10m).** Click **Select and Mask...** in the options bar. Set **View: Overlay** (masked-out areas turn a red film). Pick the **Refine Edge Brush** and paint gently along any wispy edge. Nudge **Smooth** and **Feather** a touch; set **Shift Edge** slightly negative to bite off a halo. For a colored fringe, check **Decontaminate Colors** in Output Settings. **Say:** "That switches the output to New Layer with Layer Mask. Still non-destructive: your original layer is kept, just hidden."
- 7 **Step 4 (4m).** Set **Output To: Layer Mask**, click **OK**. Point at the new mask: "Exactly the black and white card from L02." Add a layer below: **Ctrl/⌘**-click the New Layer icon (or drag the new layer down), then **Edit ▶ Fill...** with a calm color, or place `l03-calm-background.jpg` there. **File ▶ Save**. Then the payoff: paint the mask to fix a stray, and **Shift**-click the mask thumbnail to turn it off and on. **Say:** "You never deleted a thing."

◆ LAB: CUT OUT A SUBJECT, THEN NOW YOU

Guided build on `l03-subject-busy-bg.jpg` (or a learner's person, pet, or product photo) placed onto `l03-calm-background.jpg` or a solid color. Solo variation: `l03-fuzzy-subject.jpg` (or a learner's hair, fur, or leafy-plant photo) using the Refine Edge Brush for the wispy parts, placed on a photo background of a different scene (`l03-other-scene.jpg`, a warm sunset that deliberately clashes). Details in `labs/module-1/README.md`.

Circulate for: Output To set to **Layer Mask** (or New Layer with Layer Mask), not Selection; the new background layer *below* the subject; no bright halo.

Definition of done: the background is hidden by a mask, not erased; the edge has no halo and isn't razor-sharp; a calmer background sits beneath; the learner can paint the mask to fix a stray; .psd saved.

◆ BEGINNER MISTAKES TO PRE-EMPT

- ◆ **Pressing Delete.** The most destructive habit in the course. If you see someone press Delete/Backspace on a selection, undo with them and say "mask it, don't erase it."
- ◆ **Output To: Selection.** They click OK and get marching ants back, but no mask. Reopen Select and Mask (**Select ▶ Select and Mask...**, **Ctrl+Alt+R / ⌘+⌘+R**) and set Output To: Layer Mask.
- ◆ **"Select and Mask" button missing.** It appears in the options bar only while a selection tool is active. Press **W** or use the Select menu.
- ◆ **"My original layer disappeared!"** Decontaminate Colors makes a new masked layer and hides the original. Show them the hidden layer's eyeball: nothing was lost.
- ◆ **New background layer lands on top** and covers the subject. New layers appear above the active one; **Ctrl/⌘**-click the New Layer icon or drag it below. If the photo is still a locked **Background** layer,

nothing can go beneath it: click its lock icon to turn it into a normal layer first.

- ◆ **Refine Edge Brush on the solid interior.** It's built for the hairline, not the middle of the subject. Paint *along* the edge.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING: SELF-CHECK + JOURNAL

Answers: **Q1 C)** A selection is temporary; a mask is the saved, editable answer; **Q2 B)** Use the Object Selection tool and draw a box around the thing you want; **Q3 A)** Hold Alt/⌥ while painting; **Q4 C)** The Refine Edge Brush, along the hairline; **Q5 B)** Layer Mask; **Q6 A)** Shift Edge slightly negative and Decontaminate Colors. Full set in the Answer Key.

Journal (3–5 min): *Which was harder: making the selection, or making the edge believable?* Tell the room: "That answer tells you where to point your practice next."

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

Fast finishers: the lesson's "Going further": select the subject, then **Select ► Inverse** (Ctrl/⌘ + Shift + I) to feel how a selection is just a boundary you can flip. In Select & Mask, try the **Refine Hair** button before brushing. Ask them to note whether the cutout's colors clash with its new background: that's the Module 4 (Compositing) question.

Struggling learners: stay on the high-contrast practice file, skip Decontaminate Colors, and aim for one thing: Output To: Layer Mask. A slightly rough edge on a real mask beats a perfect edge made by deleting pixels. Pair them with a neighbor for the Select and Mask settings.

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Remove small spots and blemishes with the Spot Healing Brush
- ◆ Choose between healing (blends texture) and cloning (copies exactly), and know when each wins
- ◆ Erase a larger distraction with Content-Aware Fill or the Remove tool
- ◆ Work non-destructively by healing on a separate layer, then export the finished image

◆ TIMING

5m	The goal + mental model: borrow good pixels
5m	Which tool for which mess? (decision tree) + the retouch-layer habit
28m	Guided build: Steps 1–4 (2 + 8 + 10 + 8)
5m	Now You: start the two-ways removal (finish at home)
7m	Self-check, recipe card, journal, Module 1 recap

◆ TEACHING SEQUENCE & LIVE-DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 Borrow good pixels (5m).** Show the L04 slider. **Say:** "Every cleanup tool does one silly-simple thing: it takes pixels from a good part of the image and lays them over a bad part. The tools differ only in how they blend." **Cloning** copies exactly (great for hard edges and patterns, ruthless if lighting differs); **healing** copies texture and then blends color and brightness in (magic on skin and skies); **Content-Aware** tools do it automatically over a whole region.
- 2 Decision tree + the habit (5m).** Draw the tree: tiny spot → **Spot Healing Brush**; whole object with hard edges, straight lines, or patterns around it → **Clone Stamp**; whole object on plain or textured surroundings (sky, sand, grass) → **Remove tool** or **Content-Aware Fill**; then blend and check at 100%. **Say:** "When in doubt, try the Remove tool first. It's the most forgiving." Then the habit: all cleanup on an **empty layer**, each tool set to sample all layers.
- 3 Step 1 (2m).** Open `l04-dusty-sky.jpg`, **Save As** `cleanup-working.psd`. Click the **New Layer** icon, double-click the name and type `retouch`. Press J for the Spot Healing Brush and check **Sample All Layers** in the options bar. **Say:** "Everything I fix lands on this sheet. Hide it and the original is pristine."
- 4 Step 2 (8m).** Zoom to 100% (Ct r l / ⌘ + 1). Set the brush just a little larger than a spot ([and] resize) and single-click it. Work left to right, top to bottom. **Say:** "Methodical beats fast. Don't miss any."

- 5 **Step 3 (10m). Option A, Remove tool** (in the healing group; Photoshop 2023 v24.5 and later): still on `retouch`, check Sample All Layers, brush over the whole pole or bird, release. Touch up with a second pass. **Option B, Content-Aware Fill:** click the **photo** layer first (it may not be able to sample from an empty layer), loosely select the object with the Lasso (L) leaving a margin, **Edit ► Content-Aware Fill...**, green-brush where it should sample from, set **Output To: New Layer**, **OK**. **Say:** "Now click the retouch layer again before the next step." Demo both on two different distractions so the room sees each.
- 6 **Step 4 (8m).** Find a hard edge the healing smeared (the roofline in the practice file). Press S for the Clone Stamp and set **Sample: Current & Below** (or All Layers). **Say:** "This is a separate setting from the Spot Healing checkbox. Left on Current Layer, it samples our empty layer and paints nothing." **Alt/⌘**-click a clean area to sample, then paint over the flaw. Final 100% pass, **File ► Save, File ► Export ► Export As ► JPG 80% → `cleanup-final.jpg`**. **Say:** "Module 1 deliverable: done."

◆ LAB: CLEAN & EXPORT, THEN NOW YOU

Guided build on `104-dusty-sky.jpg` (or a learner photo with dust or a distraction). Solo variation on `104-photobomb.jpg` or a learner photo with a photobomber, trash can, or power line: remove it once with the Remove tool and once with Content-Aware Fill, compare, and clean the tell-tale signs with the Clone Stamp. Start it in class; finish it at home. Details in `labs/module-1/README.md`.

Circulate for: a `retouch` layer that actually has paint on it (toggle its eyeball: the spots should come back); zoom at 100% during spot work; Clone Stamp Sample menu not on Current Layer.

Definition of done: all cleanup on a separate layer; no spots at 100%; the main distraction gone with no obvious smear or repeat; crisp edges near the repair; .psd saved and `cleanup-final.jpg` exported.

◆ BEGINNER MISTAKES TO PRE-EMPT

- ◆ **Healing does nothing on the empty layer.** Sample All Layers is unchecked. Check it in the options bar.
- ◆ **Clone Stamp paints nothing** or warns that the area to clone hasn't been defined. Either Sample is still on Current Layer, or they never **Alt/⌘**-clicked a source point.
- ◆ **Retouching straight onto the photo.** The photo layer was highlighted. Toggle the retouch layer's eyeball: if nothing changes, the work went onto the photo. Undo and redo on retouch.
- ◆ **Content-Aware Fill grayed out or odd.** It needs an active selection, and the photo layer should be active when you open it. Afterward, click back on retouch.
- ◆ **Working zoomed out.** Spots look fine at fit-to-screen and obvious at 100%. Make **Ctr/Cmd + 1** a reflex.
- ◆ **Brush far bigger than the spot** drags in neighboring edges and smears. "Just a little larger than the spot."
- ◆ **Repeats and smears** from content-aware tools. Check at 100%; redo with a smaller selection or clean the remnant with the Clone Stamp.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING: SELF-CHECK + JOURNAL

Answers: **Q1** B) Healing blends texture into its surroundings; cloning copies pixels exactly; **Q2** C) So the original is never touched and mistakes are easy to erase; **Q3** A) Sample All Layers is unchecked; **Q4** C) Clone Stamp; **Q5** B) Set Sample to Current & Below and Alt/⌘-click a clean source; **Q6** A) One pass at 100%, then view fit-to-screen. Full set in the Answer Key.

Journal (3–5 min): *Look back at your Module 0 journal entry, the image you dreamed of making. Which specific skill from these three lessons gets you closest to it?*

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

Fast finishers: the lesson's "Going further": combine L03 and L04 by cutting out a subject and cleaning the background behind it, a mini version of Module 4 compositing. Or try the **Healing Brush** (not Spot), where they Alt/⌘-click their own sample point, near an edge the Spot Healing Brush smeared.

Struggling learners: two tools only today: Spot Healing Brush for spots and the Remove tool for the pole. Skip Content-Aware Fill and the Clone Stamp; the recipe card covers them for later. The must-haves are the retouch layer and the export.

CLOSING THE SESSION

MODULE 1 WRAP-UP (5 MIN, 2:55–3:00)

Recap the arc: **read a layer stack → target an edit with a mask → make a believable selection and bake it into a mask → clean up without destroying a pixel.** Exit ticket (on a sticky note): "Black ___, white ___." Homework from the lesson's "Before the Next Module": run the full Module 1 workflow on one fresh photo end to end (mask an adjustment, cut out the subject, clean the frame, export), finish the L04 solo variation, and **save your best result:** learners will re-grade it in Session 3. Preview Session 3 (Module 2): "Your photo is clean and controlled. Next we make it beautiful: Camera Raw, Curves, and Smart Objects."

Module 2: Light & Color

How to teach the three lessons that turn a clean-but-flat photo into a finished, fully re-editable color grade: develop in Camera Raw, shape tone and color with Curves, and wrap it all in a Smart Object. One working file (`grade-working.psd`) runs through the whole session, so protect it and make sure everyone saves.

3 lessons

3 hrs incl. labs & break

Lessons L05-L07

Level Beginner, week 2

Maps to Session 3

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

- Same rhythm as every module: **Frame** → **Demo** → **Lab** → **Check**. Each lesson has a live-demo script (what to click and what to say), a lab, and a short self-check from the workbook. Every lesson ends with a learning-journal prompt.
- Demo on the projector, then let them do it on their own screen.** In this module the projector will lie to you about color (see the warning below), so demos show *the steps*, and learners judge *the result* on their own monitors.
- Teal** = hands-on, **amber** = watch-outs. In Module 2 the watch-outs are mostly about **overdoing it** (huge slider moves, wild channel curves) and **losing the non-destructive chain** (forgetting to convert to a Smart Object).

THE #1 RISK OF SESSION 3: JUDGING COLOR ON THE WRONG SCREEN

Projectors and uncalibrated laptops shift color and crush shadows. A grade that looks neutral on the wall may be green on a laptop. Say it out loud at the start: **"Watch my clicks on the projector, judge your color on your own screen."** Ask learners to turn off Night Light (Windows) or True Tone / Night Shift (Mac) and set screen brightness to roughly the middle for the session. Pre-empt this and you avoid half an hour of "mine looks different."

BEFORE THE SESSION

- Photoshop 2025 or 2026 installed on every machine; open **Filter ► Camera Raw Filter...** once on each so the first launch delay happens before class.
- Copy `labs/module-2/practice/` to every machine (or a shared drive). Files: `l05-flat-cast.jpg`, `l05-green-indoor.jpg`, `l06-flat-landscape.jpg`, `l06-tone-ramp.png`, `l07-badge-crisp.png`, `l07-subject-busy-bg.jpg`. See `labs/module-2/README.md`.

- ◆ Remind learners (in the pre-session email) to bring 2–3 of their own photos: one flat or wrongly colored (overcast or indoor), one with a sky, one with a clear subject.
- ◆ Have a finished `grade-working.psd` of your own open in a second tab, so you can show "where we're heading" and rescue anyone whose file goes missing.

SESSION 3 AGENDA (3 HOURS)

CLOCK	SEGMENT	MIN	NOTES
0:00–0:08	Welcome, Module 1 recap, today's goal	8	Quick recall: "black hides, white reveals." Show a finished grade as the destination. Screen-settings reminder.
0:08–0:23	L05 frame + live demo	15	Digital darkroom, global before local, Smart Object → Camera Raw
0:23–0:45	L05 lab: develop a flat photo	22	Practice file or own photo; save <code>grade-working.psd</code>
0:45–0:50	L05 check	5	Self-check Q1–Q6 (quick show of hands); journal prompt assigned as homework
0:50–1:10	L06 frame + live demo	20	Reading the graph, S-curve, Blue/Red channels, masked Curves
1:10–1:35	L06 lab: contrast & color	25	Build on the same file; masked second Curves layer
1:35–1:40	L06 check	5	Self-check Q1–Q6
1:40–1:52	Break	12	Everyone saves before leaving the seat
1:52–2:07	L07 frame + live demo	15	Container model, crisp-vs-mushy scale test, Smart Filter + filter mask, export
2:07–2:32	L07 lab: finish the grade & export	25	Deliverable: <code>module2-grade-final.jpg</code>
2:32–2:37	L07 check	5	Self-check Q1–Q6
2:37–2:50	Grade gallery	13	3 volunteers show before/after (toggle the Smart Filter eye). Praise restraint.
2:50–3:00	Wrap-up, journal, preview Session 4	10	Module 2 journal prompt (5 min in class); ask for a consented portrait for next time

Three lessons in three hours is tight, so every lesson's solo variation is an **if time / homework** item, not class time. If you run behind, shorten the grade gallery first. Never cut the L07 export: the exported JPEG is the module

deliverable. Learners write the L05 and L06 journal entries at home; the L07 prompt gets 5 minutes in the wrap-up.

MODULE AT A GLANCE

LESSON	TOPIC	TIME	LEARNERS LEAVE ABLE TO...
L05	The Develop Step: Camera Raw	42m	Neutralize a color cast and set global tone in a re-editable Camera Raw Smart Filter
L06	Curves: Precise Tone & Color	50m	Read the Curves graph, add an S-curve, color-grade a channel, and mask Curves to one region
L07	Smart Objects & Finishing the Grade	45m	Explain Smart Objects, add a masked Smart Filter, transform without loss, and export the finished grade

The module is one story told on one file: **develop it honestly → shape its light and color → keep every decision reversible and ship it**. Times above include demo, lab, and check.

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Open a photo as a **Smart Object** so Camera Raw becomes a re-editable **Smart Filter**
- ◆ Fix a color cast with **White Balance** (Temperature and Tint)
- ◆ Set global tone with **Exposure, Contrast, Highlights, Shadows, Whites and Blacks**
- ◆ Explain why you develop *globally first*, before any local edits

◆ TEACHING SEQUENCE AND DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 **Frame: the digital darkroom (3m).** Open `l05-flat-cast.jpg`. Say: "This is what cameras often hand you: an orange cast and flat, lifeless contrast. Camera Raw is the developing station in an old darkroom. It gets the raw light honest before we make any creative choice." Write the mantra on the board: **global before local; develop before you decorate.**
- 2 **Demo: protect and wrap (2m).** Click **File ▶ Save As →** `grade-working.psd`. Say: "Protect the original first, always." Right-click the layer **on its name, not the thumbnail ▶ Convert to Smart Object**. Zoom in on the thumbnail's page badge. Say: "That badge means the photo is sealed in a protective container. We'll unpack that in Lesson 2.3. Today it just means nothing we do gets baked in."
- 3 **Demo: open Camera Raw (1m).** **Filter ▶ Camera Raw Filter...** (Shift + Ctrl + A / ⌘ + ⌘ + A). Point at the preview on the left and the sliders on the right.
- 4 **Demo: white balance first (3m).** Pick the **White Balance eyedropper**, click the gray card or the white wall in the practice file. The cast snaps away. Say: "Click something that should be neutral: a cloud, a white shirt, gray pavement." Then nudge **Temperature** (cooler if still orange) and **Tint** (off any green or magenta). Model the "look away" habit: Say: "Your eyes adapt to a cast in seconds. Look at the wall for a moment, then look back. Still natural? Then it's right."
- 5 **Demo: tone, top to bottom (5m).** **Exposure** for overall brightness; **Contrast** a gentle nudge; **Highlights** down to recover the bright sky; **Shadows** up to reveal dark detail. Then hold **Alt / ⌘** and drag **Whites** until the first specks appear, back off a hair; repeat on **Blacks**. Say: "A crisp photo has a real black somewhere and a clean white somewhere. That's the full-range check."
- 6 **Demo: commit, but not really (1m).** Click **OK**. Show Camera Raw nested under the Smart Object in the Layers panel. Toggle its  for before/after, double-click the filter name to reopen: every slider is exactly where you left it. **File ▶ Save (Ctrl/⌘ + S)**. Say: "We'll open this same file in the next lesson, so save it where you can find it."

◆ LAB: DEVELOP A FLAT PHOTO (22 MIN)

Learners follow the lesson's four steps on `105-flat-cast.jpg` or their own flat or indoor photo, and save `grade-working.psd`. **If time / homework:** the solo variation (the same photo developed two ways, cool and crisp vs. warm and golden) or try `105-green-indoor.jpg`, which needs **Tint**, not just Temperature. **Circulate for:** the page badge on the thumbnail *before* Camera Raw opens; eyedropper clicks on truly neutral objects (not skin, not a colored wall); Whites and Blacks set with the **Alt/⌘** clipping preview; the file saved as `.psd`.

Definition of done: the lesson's checklist. Smart Object badge, neutral whites, a true black and a clean white, detail in highlights and shadows, Camera Raw is a Smart Filter, `grade-working.psd` saved.

◆ BEGINNER MISTAKES TO PRE-EMPT

- ◆ **Skipping Convert to Smart Object.** Camera Raw Filter still runs on a normal layer, but it bakes in. If a learner's Layers panel shows no Smart Filter under the photo, undo (**Ctrl/⌘ + Z**), convert, and redo. It takes one minute now and saves the whole module.
- ◆ **Right-clicking the thumbnail.** That opens a different menu. Right-click on the layer *name*.
- ◆ **Eyedropper on the wrong thing.** Clicking skin, sky, or a colored wall "neutralizes" something that shouldn't be neutral and throws the whole photo off. Guide them to a white or gray object.
- ◆ **Huge slider moves.** Beginners slam Exposure and Contrast. Demonstrate small moves and the "look away and look back" check.
- ◆ **Panel layout differs from the diagram.** Depending on the Camera Raw version, the sliders may be grouped in one Basic section or split into separate sections (for example, tone in one, White Balance in another). The lesson flags this. Teach the *order* (White Balance first, then tone top to bottom), not the physical position on screen.

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

- ◆ **Fast learners (if time, else homework):** develop the same photo two ways (solo variation), then drag Exposure to an extreme, click OK, reopen, and dial it back to prove there's no quality loss. Point them at the **Curve** panel inside Camera Raw as a preview of L06.
- ◆ **Struggling learners:** reduce the job to two moves: the eyedropper, then Exposure. Once those land, add Whites/Blacks with the clipping preview. A two-slider develop that's saved properly beats a six-slider one that isn't.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING: WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK + JOURNAL

Answers: **Q1 B)** So Camera Raw is applied as a re-editable Smart Filter; **Q2 A)** Click the White Balance eyedropper on something that should be neutral; **Q3 C)** White Balance → Exposure → Contrast → Highlights/Shadows → Whites/Blacks; **Q4 A)** Where the image is clipping; **Q5 B)** Fix the whole image first, then make local tweaks; **Q6 C)** Yes, the Camera Raw Filter runs on any layer. Full explanations in the Answer Key. Assign the **Learning Journal** prompt as homework: *Which mattered more for your photo: fixing the color cast, or setting the tone?*

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Read the Curves graph: input across, output up, the diagonal is "no change"
- ◆ Add contrast with a classic **S-curve**, and flatten it for a soft, filmic look
- ◆ Color-grade by bending the **Red, Green and Blue** channels
- ◆ Apply a Curves adjustment layer to only part of the photo with a **mask**

◆ TEACHING SEQUENCE AND DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 **Frame: defuse the fear (2m).** Say: "Curves is the one advanced control worth learning if you learn only one. It looks like math class. It isn't. It's a picture of 'make these tones brighter, those darker.' If it's confusing right now, add the word **yet**."
- 2 **Demo: read the graph on a ramp (5m).** Open `l06-tone-ramp.png` (a black-to-white gradient with numbered steps). Click the  button at the bottom of the Layers panel ► **Curves**. Say: "Every tone walks in along the bottom, its input, and walks out up the side, its output. The straight diagonal means every tone leaves exactly as it came in." Drag the middle point up: the whole ramp brightens. Drag it down: it darkens. Reset.
- 3 **Demo: the S-curve (4m).** Switch to `grade-working.psd` (or `l06-flat-landscape.jpg`). Add Curves. Click about a quarter of the way up the line and drag gently down; click about three quarters up and drag gently up. Say: "Shadows down, highlights up. That's an S. The steeper the middle, the more contrast. Small moves, big results." Then show the opposite: lift the bottom-left corner for milky, faded blacks. Say: "That's the matte, vintage look."
- 4 **Demo: color-grade with a channel (4m).** Change the channel dropdown from **RGB** to **Blue**. Lift the shadow end slightly (cool shadows), drop the highlight end slightly (warm highlights). Say: "On its own, Blue gives you blue and yellow. For a truer teal, switch to **Red** and pull its shadow end down slightly. Less red means more cyan." Warn: a few pixels of drag is already a strong grade.
- 5 **Demo: grade one region only (5m).** Add a second Curves layer and brighten it noticeably. Click its **mask thumbnail**. Press D, then X so black is the foreground color, then **Alt + Backspace / ⌘ + Delete** to fill the mask black (or **Ctrl / ⌘ + I** to invert the white mask). Press X for white and paint over the subject with a soft brush (B). Say: "That's the mask from Lesson 1.1, reused at a higher level. Global tone plus a local mask is the core loop of nearly every professional grade." **File ► Save**.

◆ LAB: CONTRAST & COLOR (25 MIN)

On `grade-working.psd` from L05 (fallback: `l06-flat-landscape.jpg`), then Save As `grade-working.psd`, learners add an S-curve, nudge at least one color channel, and add a second, masked Curves layer that grades only one region (the subject or the sky). Save for L07.

Circulate for: the mask thumbnail (not the photo) selected before painting; black filling the mask, white painting the region; curve moves that are small; Curves layers sitting *above* the Camera Raw Smart Object.

Definition of done: the lesson's checklist, including "nothing looks blotchy or banded at normal viewing size."

◆ BEGINNER MISTAKES TO PRE-EMPT

- ◆ **"Where did the graph go?"** The Curves graph lives in the **Properties** panel. If it gets closed, double-click the Curves layer's adjustment icon (the left thumbnail, not the mask) to bring it back.
- ◆ **Too many points.** Two points make an S. Five points make a roller coaster. To delete a point, drag it off the graph.
- ◆ **Wild channel curves.** "My colors went crazy." They moved the Blue or Red channel too far. Reset the channel and move a few pixels only.
- ◆ **Painting on the photo, not the mask.** If paint strokes appear as white smears on the image, they had the image thumbnail selected. Undo, click the mask thumbnail (it gets a highlight frame), repeat.
- ◆ **Aggressive S on skin and skies.** Strong curves make skin blotchy and skies banded. That's the cue for the masked, local approach.

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

- ◆ **Fast learners (if time, else homework):** the solo variation: three grades with Curves only (punchy, filmic, moody), each exported as a JPEG and compared; add a masked Curves vignette that darkens the frame edges. Show them the on-image adjustment tool (the pointing-hand icon): drag up or down directly on a tone and Photoshop moves the matching point.
- ◆ **Struggling learners:** use the tone ramp for the first S-curve so they can see what each point does, then repeat on the photo. Skip channel grading until the masked Curves layer works; the mask is the more important skill.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING: WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK + JOURNAL

Answers: **Q1** A) Every tone leaves exactly as it came in: no change; **Q2** C) Shadows point down, highlights point up; **Q3** B) Milky, faded blacks; **Q4** A) Cool shadows and warm highlights; **Q5** B) Fill its mask black, then paint white over the subject; **Q6** C) Above it. Full explanations in the Answer Key. Journal prompt (homework): *Did Curves feel like math or like a dimmer switch by the end? Describe the S-curve to yourself in one plain sentence.*

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Explain what a Smart Object is: a protective container around the original pixels
- ◆ Scale, warp, and transform without losing quality
- ◆ Apply **Smart Filters** (like Gaussian Blur or Camera Raw) that stay re-editable and maskable
- ◆ Assemble Camera Raw and Curves into a finished, fully non-destructive grade and export it

◆ TEACHING SEQUENCE AND DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 **Frame: the sealed box (2m).** Say: "A Smart Object is a sealed container with your original pixels safe inside. When you scale it or filter it, Photoshop doesn't change the pixels. It writes an instruction on the outside of the box and re-renders from the pristine original every time." Put the one-line definition on the board: **a Smart Object stores your pixels; everything you do to it is a re-editable instruction.**
- 2 **Demo: the crisp-vs-mushy test (4m).** Open `l07-badge-crisp.png`. Duplicate the layer (`Ctrl/⌘ + J`); convert only one copy to a Smart Object. Put them side by side. On each: `Ctrl/⌘ + T`, scale to 30%, Enter; then `Ctrl/⌘ + T`, scale back to 100%, Enter. Zoom to 100% (`Ctrl/⌘ + 1`). Say: "Same transform, two fates. The normal layer threw its pixels away. The Smart Object re-rendered from the sealed original." This is the moment the concept lands; let the room react.
- 3 **Demo: a Smart Filter with a mask (4m).** Back on `grade-working.psd`, select the Smart Object. **Filter ▶ Sharpen ▶ Smart Sharpen** (or **Filter ▶ Blur ▶ Gaussian Blur**). Show it nesting under the Smart Object, above Camera Raw. Say: "Newest filter on top, and filters apply from the bottom up." Click the white **Smart Filters** mask and paint black over an area you don't want filtered. Say: "Black hides, white reveals, from Lesson 1.1, now controlling a filter."
- 4 **Demo: turn a blur into a glow (2m).** On a Gaussian Blur Smart Filter, double-click the small **Blending Options** icon at the right end of the filter's row. Set **Mode: Soft Light** (or Screen) and **Opacity** about 20–40%. Say: "Now it's a dreamy glow, not a blurry photo."
- 5 **Demo: finish and export (3m).** Fit to screen (`Ctrl/⌘ + 0`), tweak a Curves layer, double-click Camera Raw to show it's still live. **File ▶ Save** the layered `.psd` (the master). Then **File ▶ Export ▶ Export As ▶ JPG**, quality 80% → `module2-grade-final.jpg`. Say: "The PSD is your master. The JPEG is the deliverable. Keep both."

◆ LAB: FINISH THE GRADE (25 MIN)

Learners confirm their photo is a Smart Object, add at least one more Smart Filter and paint its mask, run the scale-down/scale-up test, then save the `.psd` and export `module2-grade-final.jpg`. **If time / homework:** the fake shallow-depth-of-field drill on `l07-subject-busy-bg.jpg` (Gaussian Blur Smart Filter, paint the filter mask black over the subject so only the background blurs).

Circulate for: Smart Filters nested under the photo layer (not on a separate layer); filter masks painted black where the filter should be hidden; the exported file actually present on disk with the right name.

Definition of done: Camera Raw plus at least one more Smart Filter nested under the Smart Object; crisp after the scale test; contrast and color from re-editable Curves layers; **.psd** master saved and **.jpg** exported.

◆ BEGINNER MISTAKES TO PRE-EMPT

- ◆ **"Smart Filters are turned off while transforming."** Photoshop may warn about this when they press `Ctrl/⌘ + T`. Tell them in advance: click OK, the filters come back as soon as you commit.
- ◆ **Trying to heal or paint on the Smart Object.** Healing and cloning tools want normal pixels. The pattern from the lesson: retouch on normal layers first, then convert to a Smart Object for filtering and transforming. (Module 3 relies on this.)
- ◆ **Double-clicking the wrong thing.** Double-clicking the Smart Object *thumbnail* opens the contents in a new tab. Double-clicking the filter *name* reopens its settings. If a new tab appears by surprise, close it without changes.
- ◆ **Export confusion.** Learners who "Save As JPEG" can lose track of which file is the master. Insist on the two-step: Save the **.psd**, then Export As.

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

- ◆ **Fast learners (if time, else homework):** select several layers, right-click ► **Convert to Smart Object** to nest them as one; filter and transform the group. Tell them this is how compositors keep giant files manageable, a taste of Module 4. Also: double-click Camera Raw and re-grade the entire image with a new look.
- ◆ **Struggling learners:** guarantee the two essentials: the crisp-vs-mushy test (for understanding) and the export (for the deliverable). The extra Smart Filter and filter mask are a bonus.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING: WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK + JOURNAL

Answers: **Q1 C)** A container that stores your original pixels; every edit is a re-editable instruction; **Q2 B)** It re-renders from the sealed original; **Q3 A)** Paint black on the Smart Filters mask over the skin; **Q4 C)** Double-click the filter's Blending Options icon, set Soft Light or Screen at 20–40%; **Q5 B)** Healing or cloning directly on the layer's pixels; **Q6 A)** The PSD is the re-editable master; the JPEG is flat. Full explanations in the Answer Key.

Journal prompt (5 minutes in the wrap-up): *In your own words, why do professionals care so much about never committing an edit?*

CLOSING THE SESSION

MODULE 2 WRAP-UP (10 MIN, SESSION 3)

Everyone should leave with `grade-working.psd` (Camera Raw + Curves + masked Curves + a Smart Filter) and `module2-grade-final.jpg`. Recap the arc: **developed it honestly → shaped its light and color → kept every decision reversible → shipped it**. Preview Module 3: "Session 4 is about people: healing skin naturally, frequency separation, and dodge and burn."

Ask before they leave: bring a portrait for Session 4. A self-portrait is ideal; any other person must have agreed to being photographed, edited, and shown to the class. Free-license portraits (for example from Pexels or Unsplash, after checking the license) are fine too. See `labs/module-3/README.md` for what makes a good practice portrait.

GROWTH-MINDSET MOMENT

Curves is where many beginners decide they're "not technical." Name that out loud and celebrate the first S-curve in the room. Remind them the lesson's own advice: if it's confusing, add the word *yet*. Five S-curves on five photos (the homework) turns it into muscle memory.

Module 3: Retouching

How to teach the three lessons that take learners through a complete, natural portrait retouch: heal the temporary and respect the permanent, even skin tone with frequency separation, and sculpt dimension with dodge and burn. One portrait file (`portrait-working.psd`) runs through the whole session. This is the module where judgment matters as much as technique, so model restraint at every step.

3 lessons

3 hrs incl. labs & break

Lessons L08-L10

Level Practitioner tier

Maps to Session 4

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

- Same rhythm as every module: **Frame** → **Demo** → **Lab** → **Check**. Each lesson has a live-demo script, a lab, and a workbook self-check. Every lesson ends with a learning-journal prompt.
- **Demo on the practice portrait, never on a learner's face.** The illustrated practice faces (`L08-` , `L09-` , `L10-` files) have known flaws placed on purpose, so your demo always works and nobody's appearance is discussed in front of the room.
- **Teal** = hands-on, **amber** = watch-outs. In Module 3 the watch-outs are **overdoing it** (erasing freckles, plastic skin, harsh dodging), **sampling settings** on empty layers, and the **Apply Image recipe** in L09.

CONSENT, RESPECT, AND HOW WE TALK ABOUT FACES

Portrait retouching is personal. Set three ground rules in the first ten minutes and hold them all session: **1)** Only edit portraits of yourself, of people who agreed to be edited and shown in class, or free-license portraits whose license allows it. **2)** Nobody's portrait goes on the projector without their say-so. **3)** In critique, **talk about the edit, never the person's looks**: "the heal left a patch here," not "their skin is bad." The lesson's own position is the course position: retouch the temporary, respect the permanent, and never set impossible standards.

BEFORE THE SESSION

- Copy `labs/module-3/practice/` to every machine: `L08-portrait-blemishes.jpg` , `L09-portrait-blotchy.jpg` , `L10-portrait-flat.jpg` , `L09-skin-swatch.jpg` . Keep `labs/module-3/instructor/L08-flaw-map-INSTRUCTOR.png` for yourself (it marks every temporary and permanent feature on the L08 face). See `labs/module-3/README.md` .

- ◆ Print the **Frequency Separation recipe card** (from the workbook, L09) one per learner, or put it on a slide that stays up during the L09 lab.
- ◆ Confirm the practice files open as **8 Bits/Channel (Image ► Mode)**. The L09 Apply Image recipe in the lesson depends on bit depth.
- ◆ Rehearse L09 once on the practice file within the week. It's the one demo in the module where a skipped click shows up as a gray screen in front of the room.

SESSION 4 AGENDA (3 HOURS)

CLOCK	SEGMENT	MIN	NOTES
0:00–0:10	Welcome, Module 2 recap, ground rules	10	Consent and respect rules; "great retouching is invisible"; confirm everyone has a portrait (own or practice file)
0:10–0:22	L08 frame + live demo	12	Temporary vs permanent, survey at 100%, retouch layer, Spot Healing + Healing Brush
0:22–0:42	L08 lab: retouch a portrait	20	Save <code>portrait-working.psd</code>
0:42–0:47	L08 check	5	Self-check Q1–Q6; journal prompt as homework
0:47–1:07	L09 frame + live demo	20	Two sheets, Stamp Visible, LOW blur, Apply Image, Linear Light, even LOW, fix HIGH
1:07–1:37	L09 lab: separate & smooth	30	Recipe card visible the whole time; circulate hard
1:37–1:42	L09 check	5	Self-check Q1–Q6
1:42–1:54	Break	12	Everyone saves first
1:54–2:09	L10 frame + live demo	15	50% gray Soft Light layer, dodge, burn, eyes and teeth, export
2:09–2:34	L10 lab: sculpt & finish	25	Deliverable: <code>portrait-final.jpg</code>
2:34–2:39	L10 check	5	Self-check Q1–Q6
2:39–2:52	Critique: "Would they recognize themselves?"	13	Volunteers only; toggle each retouch layer for before/after; talk about the edit, not the face
2:52–3:00	Wrap-up, journal, preview Session 5	8	L10 "how far you've come" journal prompt in class

L09 gets the biggest block on purpose. If you run behind, shorten the critique first, then drop the optional iris Curves layer in L10. Every lesson's solo variation is an **if time / homework** item. Never cut the L10 export: `portrait-`

`final.jpg` is the module deliverable.

MODULE AT A GLANCE

LESSON	TOPIC	TIME	LEARNERS LEAVE ABLE TO...
L08	Natural Skin: Heal, Don't Erase	37m	Remove temporary blemishes on a separate retouch layer and dial it back so it looks natural
L09	Frequency Separation	55m	Split texture from color and even blotchy tone without losing pores
L10	Dodge & Burn: Sculpting Light	45m	Sculpt a face on a 50% gray Soft Light layer, brighten eyes and teeth, and export the finished portrait

The module is one story on one face: **clean it (temporary only) → even it (tone, not texture) → light it (follow the existing light) → ship it.** Times include demo, lab, and check.

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Retouch skin non-destructively on a separate empty layer
- ◆ Remove temporary blemishes with the **Spot Healing Brush** and **Healing Brush**
- ◆ Decide what to fix and what to leave: the ethics of a natural retouch
- ◆ Dial back the work with layer opacity so it never looks overdone

◆ TEACHING SEQUENCE AND DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 **Frame: temporary vs permanent (2m).** Say: "Great retouching is invisible. Your subject should look like themselves on their best day, not like a wax figure." Draw two columns on the board. **Temporary** (would it be there next week? no): a spot, a stray hair, shine, lint. **Permanent:** freckles, moles, laugh lines, scars, the shape of the nose. Say: "Heal the temporary, keep the permanent. When unsure, keep it. You can always reduce later."
- 2 **Demo: survey first (2m).** Open `l08-portrait-blemishes.jpg`, **File ► Save As →** `portrait-working.psd`. Zoom to 100% (**Ctrl/⌘ + 1**) and pan slowly across the face *without touching a tool*. Think aloud: "Red spot on the cheek: temporary. Freckles across the nose: permanent. Mole by the lip: permanent. That dark hair across the forehead: temporary." Say: "This sixty-second survey is what separates natural from overdone."
- 3 **Demo: the retouch layer (3m).** New empty layer, name it `retouch`. Spot Healing Brush (**J**): options bar **Type: Content-Aware**, tick **Sample All Layers**. Say: "It reads the face below but writes only on this layer. The original face is never touched."
- 4 **Demo: heal (3m).** Size the brush just larger than a spot (**[** and **]** resize it) and single-click. Do three open-skin spots. Then a spot at the hairline: switch to the **Healing Brush** (**Shift + J** cycles the group). Say: "Different tool, different setting." Set **Sample: Current & Below**. **Alt/⌘-click** clean skin of the same brightness nearby, then click the spot. Say: "If it still smears the edge, finish it with the Clone Stamp, **S**, same Sample setting."
- 5 **Demo: dial back and check (2m).** Lower the `retouch` layer's Opacity to about 85–90%. Toggle its  off and on. Say: "With the layer on, is it still clearly the same person on a good day? Then we nailed it." Save.

◆ LAB: RETOUCH A PORTRAIT (20 MIN)

Learners work on their own consented portrait or `l08-portrait-blemishes.jpg`. They list their temporary and permanent items in the workbook *before* healing, then follow the lesson's four steps and save

portrait-working.psd (the file carries through L09 and L10).

Circulate for: a named, empty **retouch** layer that is actually selected while healing; **Sample All Layers** ticked on Spot Healing; **Sample: Current & Below** on the Healing Brush; zoom at 100%; freckles and the mole still present.

Definition of done: the lesson checklist. All healing on the retouch layer; temporary blemishes gone; freckles, moles, and lines still there; opacity slightly under 100%; still the same person.

◆ BEGINNER MISTAKES TO PRE-EMPTY

- ◆ **"The brush does nothing."** On an empty layer, Spot Healing without **Sample All Layers** (or the Healing Brush left on **Sample: Current Layer**) has nothing to read. Check the options bar for the tool that's active; the two tools use *different* settings.
- ◆ **Healing on the photo layer.** The **retouch** layer was created but the Background stayed selected. Look at which layer is highlighted before the first click.
- ◆ **The clean sweep.** Removing every freckle and line "while you're in there." That's the permanent bucket, and it's what makes a face look plastic. Point back at their written lists.
- ◆ **Color patches after healing.** The source was a shadow or highlight. Sample from skin of the same brightness, or pick the source deliberately with the Healing Brush.
- ◆ **Brush far too big.** A brush much larger than the spot drags in hairline, eyebrow, or lip texture. "Just larger than the blemish."

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

- ◆ **Fast learners (if time, else homework):** the solo variation: retouch two copies, one tasteful and one deliberately overdone, and compare side by side. Then the "reduce, not erase" move: heal a blemish that sits on a freckle on its *own* new layer and lower that layer's opacity so a hint returns (lowering the main retouch layer would fade every heal at once).
- ◆ **Struggling learners:** use the practice file (flaws are obvious and known) and only the Spot Healing Brush in open skin. Add the Healing Brush for the hairline spot once the basic click works.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING: WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK + JOURNAL

Answers: **Q1 C)** A red spot that wasn't there last week; **Q2 A)** The original face is never touched and the work can be reduced or deleted; **Q3 B)** Its Sample menu is on Current Layer; set it to Current & Below; **Q4 C)** Switch to the Healing Brush and Alt/⌘-click clean skin as the source; **Q5 A)** A whisper of the original keeps it believable; **Q6 B)** Survey at 100% and sort temporary vs permanent. Full explanations in the Answer Key.

Journal prompt (homework): *Where's your personal line between "cleanup" and "changing who someone is"?*

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Explain **high frequency** (texture) vs **low frequency** (color and tone)
- ◆ Build a frequency-separation setup with **Gaussian Blur + Apply Image**
- ◆ Even out blotchy skin tone on the color layer, texture untouched
- ◆ Fix stray texture on the texture layer, color untouched

◆ TEACHING SEQUENCE AND DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 **Frame: two sheets of skin (3m).** Say: "Healing fixes spots, but it can't even out blotchy tone. Blurring the skin turns it to plastic because blur smooths texture and color together. So we split them." Draw two stacked sheets: **LOW** = the paint (color, shading, blotches); **HIGH** = the texture stamped into it (pores, fine hairs). Say: "The words 'Apply Image' and 'Linear Light' sound scary. You set them once, as a recipe. Ninety percent of this technique is painting softly on the color layer."
- 2 **Demo: stamp and duplicate (2m).** Open `l09-portrait-blotchy.jpg` (or continue `portrait-working.psd`). With the top layer selected, **Stamp Visible:** `Ctrl + Alt + Shift + E / ⌘ + ⌥ + ⬆ + E`. Duplicate it twice (`Ctrl / ⌘ + J`, twice). Name the lower copy **LOW**, the upper copy **HIGH**. Hide **HIGH**.
- 3 **Demo: make LOW (3m).** Select **LOW**. **Filter ▶ Blur ▶ Gaussian Blur**. Raise the radius slowly while watching the cheek. Say: "Stop when the blotches are gone and the pores just disappear. Often 6 to 12 pixels on a portrait. No more." Click OK.
- 4 **Demo: make HIGH (5m).** Show and select **HIGH**. **Image ▶ Apply Image**. Read each setting aloud as you set it: **Layer: LOW, Blending: Subtract, Scale: 2, Offset: 128**. OK. Say: "Flat gray with faint texture: that's correct, don't panic." Set **HIGH**'s blend mode to **Linear Light**. The face snaps back. Say: "Looks identical to the original. The difference is that texture and color now live on separate layers." Mention the 16-bit recipe only as a warning: Add, Scale 2, Offset 0, Invert.
- 5 **Demo: even the tone on LOW (4m).** Select **LOW**. Lasso a loose loop around a blotchy cheek patch, **Select ▶ Modify ▶ Feather** 10–20 px, then a small Gaussian Blur. Deselect (`Ctrl / ⌘ + D`). Then show the alternative: soft Brush at low opacity, `Alt / ⌥`-click to sample good nearby color, paint gently. Toggle **HIGH** off to show the "paint" sheet, then on: the pores are still razor sharp.
- 6 **Demo: fix texture on HIGH (3m).** Select **HIGH**. Healing Brush with **Sample: Current Layer**. Say: "Current Layer this time. Sampling other layers would drag color onto the texture sheet." Remove the flyaway hair. Save.

◆ LAB: SEPARATE & SMOOTH (30 MIN)

Learners build the setup on `portrait-working.psd` (or `109-portrait-blotchy.jpg` if their own portrait has little uneven tone) with the recipe card in view, even the tone on `LOW`, fix one bit of texture on `HIGH`, and save.

Circulate for: the checkpoint after Linear Light: "Does it look identical to the original?" If yes, they're past the hard part. If not, stop and diagnose (see below) before any smoothing. Then check that learners are on the correct sheet for each fix.

Definition of done: the lesson checklist. LOW blurred, HIGH in Linear Light; identical at first; blotches evened on LOW; pores still crisp; stray texture fixed on HIGH without color shift.

◆ BEGINNER MISTAKES TO PRE-EMPT

- ◆ **Gray mess after Apply Image.** Almost always one of: blend mode not set to Linear Light; **Layer** in Apply Image left on something other than `LOW`; or the wrong recipe for the bit depth. Check **Image ► Mode**: 8 Bits/Channel = Subtract / Scale 2 / Offset 128; 16 Bits/Channel = Add / Scale 2 / Offset 0 / Invert. Fastest fix: delete `HIGH`, duplicate the stamped layer again, redo the step.
- ◆ **LOW and HIGH swapped.** Blurring the upper copy and applying the recipe to the lower one. HIGH must sit on top.
- ◆ **Blur too strong on LOW.** The face loses its natural shading and looks flat. "Just enough that the blotches and pores vanish."
- ◆ **Hard edges in the smoothing.** A Lasso selection without Feather leaves a visible outline. Feather 10–20 px first.
- ◆ **Working on the wrong sheet.** Painting on HIGH smears texture; healing on LOW does nothing useful. Say it as a mantra: **color on LOW, texture on HIGH.**
- ◆ **Stamp Visible shortcut fails.** All four keys at once; on a Mac it's ⌘⇧⌘⇧E. If a learner still can't get it, have them select all layers, duplicate them, and merge the copies (**Layer ► Merge Layers**) as a fallback.

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

- ◆ **Fast learners (if time, else homework):** the solo variation: even only the forehead and cheeks; compare against a "lazy" Gaussian Blur on a duplicate of the whole face; then put the LOW smoothing inside a group with a black mask and paint it in only where needed. Stretch: convert a copy of the practice file to 16 Bits/Channel and run the 16-bit recipe.
- ◆ **Struggling learners:** pair them with a neighbor who's past the Linear Light checkpoint, and have them work on `109-skin-swatch.jpg` (a small, flat skin patch that makes the setup fast and the result obvious) before trying the face. Success = the checkpoint plus one evened patch. The HIGH fix is a bonus.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING: WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK + JOURNAL

Answers: **Q1 B)** Color and tone: the blotches and shading; **Q2 A)** Until the blotches are gone and the pores just disappear; **Q3 C)** Subtract, Scale 2, Offset 128, then Linear Light; **Q4 A)** HIGH's blend mode isn't Linear Light (or the wrong bit-depth recipe); **Q5 B)** Healing Brush or Clone Stamp on HIGH with Sample: Current Layer; **Q6 C)**

Blur smooths texture and color together, so pores vanish. Full explanations in the Answer Key. Journal prompt (homework): *How did it feel to pull off frequency separation? Note any step you'd want to re-read.*

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Sculpt a face by **dodging** (lightening) and **burning** (darkening)
- ◆ Do it non-destructively on a **50% gray Soft Light** layer
- ◆ Add subtle life to eyes and teeth with masked adjustments
- ◆ Finish and export a complete, natural portrait retouch

◆ TEACHING SEQUENCE AND DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 **Frame: painting with light (2m).** Say: "Darkroom printers held back light to lighten an area, dodge, and added light to darken it, burn. We're lighting artists adding highlights and shadows after the shot." Point at a face: brow, nose bridge, cheekbones, chin catch light; sides, eye sockets, under the jaw fall into shadow. Say: "This isn't new. It's non-destructive editing, black-and-white like a mask, aimed at light."
- 2 **Demo: the gray layer (2m).** Open `l10-portrait-flat.jpg` (or continue the portrait). **Alt/⌘**-click the **New Layer** button. In the dialog set **Mode: Soft Light**, then tick **Fill with Soft-Light-neutral color (50% gray)**. Name it `D&B`. Say: "It's invisible. That's correct: gray vanishes in Soft Light."
- 3 **Demo: dodge (3m).** Brush (B), soft and large, **Opacity ~10%**. Press D, then X so white is the foreground. Several light passes down the nose bridge, forehead center, tops of the cheekbones, chin. Say: "Ten percent, many passes. You can always add more; you can't un-see a harsh streak."
- 4 **Demo: burn (3m).** X for black. Sides of the face, temples, under the cheekbones, under the jaw, eye sockets. Point out the practice file's light comes from the left. Say: "Follow the existing light. Dodge the left-facing planes more, burn the right. Fighting the original light looks wrong instantly." **Alt/⌘**-click the D&B layer's  to show the white/black "map" alone, then **Alt/⌘**-click again to return.
- 5 **Demo: eyes and teeth (3m).** Add a Curves layer, brighten slightly, fill its mask black (**Ctrl/⌘ + I** inverts the white mask), paint white over the whites of the eyes and the teeth with a small soft brush. Say: "Clean, not glowing."
- 6 **Demo: finish (2m).** Fit to screen (**Ctrl/⌘ + 0**), toggle D&B for before/after, **File ► Save the .psd**, then **File ► Export ► Export As ► JPG** about 80% → `portrait-final.jpg`.

◆ LAB: SCULPT & FINISH (25 MIN)

On their portrait (or `l10-portrait-flat.jpg`), learners first write down where the light comes from, then build the D&B layer, dodge and burn, add the masked Curves for eyes and teeth, save the PSD, and export `portrait-final.jpg`. If time: the optional second Curves layer masked to the irises for a little sparkle.

Circulate for: Soft Light mode *and* the 50% gray fill on the D&B layer; brush opacity around 10% (check the options bar, not just the stroke); strokes following the photo's light direction; the D&B layer selected while painting (not the portrait).

Definition of done: the lesson checklist. D&B on a 50% gray Soft Light layer; highlights and shadows follow the existing light; more three-dimensional, not painted-on; eyes and teeth subtly brightened with masked Curves; PSD saved and JPG exported.

◆ BEGINNER MISTAKES TO PRE-EMPT

- ◆ **The gray layer shows as solid gray.** The mode was left on Normal. Change the layer's blend mode to Soft Light. (If the layer is transparent instead, they skipped the "Fill with Soft-Light-neutral color" checkbox, which only becomes available after choosing Soft Light in the dialog. Fill it with 50% gray via **Edit ► Fill ► Contents: 50% Gray**, or remake the layer.)
- ◆ **Harsh streaks.** Opacity at 100% or a hard brush. Undo, set ~10%, and use a big soft brush.
- ◆ **Painting on the portrait.** White and black paint appears directly on the face. Undo and select the D&B layer.
- ◆ **Inventing light.** Dodging the shadow side "because it looks dark." Enhance what's there.
- ◆ **Glowing teeth, alien eyes.** The eyes-and-teeth Curves pushed too far, or the brush spilled onto lips and skin. Pull the curve back; refine the mask with black.
- ◆ **Reaching for the Dodge and Burn tools.** They paint directly on pixels (destructive). Fine on a duplicate for a quick fix, but the gray layer is the pro default because it stays re-editable.

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

- ◆ **Fast learners (if time, else homework):** the solo variation: gray layer only (no eyes/teeth step) to see how far light alone carries it; duplicate the D&B layer to see "too much," then dial opacity back to taste; burn a subtle vignette around the frame on the same layer.
- ◆ **Struggling learners:** dodge only the nose bridge and cheekbones, burn only under the cheekbones and jaw, then export. Three zones done well is a finished portrait. Skip the iris layer.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING: WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK + JOURNAL

Answers: **Q1 B)** Lightens (dodges) that area; **Q2 C)** 50% gray is invisible in Soft Light, so only your strokes show, and it stays re-editable; **Q3 A)** Large, soft brush at about 10% opacity, many passes; **Q4 B)** Dodge the left-facing planes, burn the right; **Q5 C)** A slightly brightened Curves layer, mask filled black, white painted over eye whites and teeth; **Q6 A)** The tools change pixels directly; the gray layer is re-editable. Full explanations in the Answer Key. Journal prompt (in class, wrap-up): *Compare your finished portrait to your very first Module 0 export. What can you do now that you couldn't three modules ago?*

CLOSING THE SESSION

MODULE 3 WRAP-UP (8 MIN, SESSION 4)

Everyone should leave with `portrait-working.psd` (retouch layer, LOW/HIGH, D&B, masked Curves) and `portrait-final.jpg`. Recap the arc: **healed the temporary → evened the tone without losing texture → sculpted with light → shipped it**. Preview Module 4: "Next session we combine two images: cut a subject out, drop it into a new scene, and match the light so it's believable."

Homework: retouch one portrait start to finish (heal → frequency separation → dodge and burn → export), subtle enough that a friend wouldn't notice it was retouched, only that it looks great.

GROWTH-MINDSET MOMENT

Frequency separation is the first technique in the course that feels genuinely advanced, and some learners will hit the gray screen at least once. Normalize it: "Everyone who does this professionally has seen that gray screen. The fix is a checklist, not talent." Celebrate the Linear Light checkpoint out loud when the room gets there.

Module 4 — Compositing

How to teach the three lessons that turn two separate images into one believable photograph: a clean, fringe-free cutout, a subject matched to the scene's light and color, and a finished image grounded with shadow, given depth, and unified with one grade. This is where every earlier module converges.

3 lessons

3 h session incl. break

Lessons L11–L13

Level Practitioner

Maps to Session 5

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

- Same rhythm as every module: **Frame** → **Demo** → **Lab** → **Check**. Each lesson has a guided build, a recipe card, a completion checklist, and a learning-journal prompt. The self-check quizzes live in the participant workbook (answers here and in the Answer Key).
- Demo live on the projector, zoomed in.** Compositing flaws are small (a 3-pixel fringe, a shadow pointing the wrong way). Zoom to 100–200% whenever you talk about an edge, or the back row sees nothing.
- Teal** = hands-on, **amber** = watch-outs. In Module 4 the watch-outs are mostly *habits*: forgetting to clip, painting on the wrong layer, and skipping decontamination.
- Shortcuts are given as **Windows / Mac**, for example **Ct r l + A l t + G / ⌘ + ⌘ + G**. Say both out loud; mixed rooms are the norm.

THE #1 RISK OF SESSION 5: ONE FILE, THREE LESSONS, THREE HOURS

L11, L12, and L13 all build the **same composite** (`composite-working.psd`). A learner whose L11 cutout is weak carries that weakness all day. Two safety nets: (1) the synthetic practice subject `l11-figure-on-green.png` is designed to cut out cleanly, so steer strugglers to it rather than a hard personal photo; (2) keep `l11-figure-cutout-reference.png` (a clean, finished transparent cutout of that figure) ready, so anyone who falls behind can place it and join L12 on time.

SESSION 5 AGENDA (3 HOURS)

CLOCK	SEGMENT	MIN	WHAT HAPPENS
0:00–0:05	Open & recap	5	One-line recap of Module 3 (dodge & burn = painting light). Show the Module 4 goal: one believable photograph. Confirm everyone has the practice files

CLOCK	SEGMENT	MIN	WHAT HAPPENS
			or their own subject + background photos open.
0:05-0:08	L11 frame	3	"The background tells on you." Show a fringed cutout on a new color.
0:08-0:23	L11 demo	15	Select Subject → Select and Mask → Refine Hair, Smart Radius, Refine Edge Brush → Decontaminate → Output.
0:23-0:47	L11 lab	24	Composite-ready cutout + saturated-color believability test.
0:47-0:50	L11 check	3	Two self-check items aloud; journal prompt assigned (write it now or tonight).
0:50-0:53	L12 frame	3	"Speak the scene's language." Brightness → color → contrast.
0:53-1:08	L12 demo	15	Place Embedded, Smart Object, scale, then three clipped adjustments.
1:08-1:32	L12 lab	24	Match the subject; squint-and-flick test.
1:32-1:35	L12 check	3	Self-check items aloud; journal prompt assigned.
1:35-1:47	Break	12	Leave composites on screen; people will look at each other's work.
1:47-1:50	L13 frame	3	Shadow (object), depth (space), unity (whole).
1:50-2:07	L13 demo	17	Contact shadow, cast shadow, haze, unifying grade + vignette, save master, Export As.
2:07-2:39	L13 lab	32	Finish and export the Module 4 deliverable.
2:39-2:42	L13 check	3	Self-check items aloud.
2:42-2:55	Gallery & critique	13	Learners show their JPG; the room runs the squint test and names the shadow direction.
2:55-3:00	Wrap & journal	5	Assign the three journal entries as homework; preview Module 5 (design and type). Remind them to keep the exported JPG: it can be the Module 5 poster's hero image.

If the room runs late, cut the gallery to 5 minutes (two or three volunteers), never the L13 lab: the exported JPG is the Module 4 Practitioner deliverable. The solo variations and "going further" extensions (second scene, light wrap, reflected light, hard-vs-soft light comparison) are **if time / homework**, listed under Differentiation.

MODULE AT A GLANCE

LESSON	TOPIC	TIME	LEARNERS LEAVE ABLE TO...
L11	Cut It Out Cleanly	45m	Produce a fringe-free cutout on a new layer with a mask, ready for any scene
L12	Make It Belong: Match Light & Color	45m	Match a subject's brightness, color, and contrast to a scene with clipped adjustments
L13	Ground It & Grade It	55m	Add contact and cast shadows, haze, and one unifying grade; save a master and export

The module is one story, told in one file: **cut it out → make it belong → ground it and grade it**. Object, then light, then the whole image.

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Cut a subject out with Select & Mask, tuned for compositing
- ◆ Rescue fine hair with the Refine Edge Brush
- ◆ Kill the tell-tale fringe with Decontaminate Colors
- ◆ Output the result as a layer with a mask, ready to drop into a scene

◆ TEACHING SEQUENCE + LIVE-DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 Frame: the background tells on you (3m).** Open `l11-figure-on-green.png`, do a quick Select Subject and plain layer mask, then add a bright orange Solid Color fill layer underneath (Layer ► New Fill Layer ► Solid Color). Zoom to 200% on the hair. Say: "See that green halo? When this person was photographed, the edge pixels picked up color from what was behind them. Move them to a sunset and that green screams 'pasted.' Today we clean it out." Delete this quick attempt.
- 2 Select, then Select and Mask (4m).** Say: "You already made selections and masks in Lesson 1.2. Same tools, higher stakes." Click: Select ► Subject. Then Select ► Select and Mask... (Ctrl+Alt+R / ⌘+⌥+R), or the Select and Mask... button in any selection tool's options bar. Set View to **On Layers** or **Overlay**. Say: "Pick a view that lets you judge the edge honestly. Overlay shows me exactly what is and isn't selected."
- 3 Rescue the hair (6m).** Click: **Refine Hair** in the options bar. Under Edge Detection tick **Smart Radius** and raise **Radius** a few pixels. Then take the **Refine Edge Brush** and paint along the wispy strands still missing. Set **Shift Edge** slightly negative. Say: "Smooth and Feather are optional. Both soften detail, so on hair I keep them at or near zero." Then deliberately drag the Refine Edge Brush across the shoulder and show the mush. Say: "Hair only. Solid edges stay solid."
- 4 Decontaminate (4m).** Click: open Output Settings, tick **Decontaminate Colors**, raise **Amount** while zoomed on the hair until the green halo disappears. Set **Output To: New Layer with Layer Mask**, click OK. Say: "Notice Photoshop forces a new layer. Decontamination rewrites edge pixels, so it can't stay fully non-destructive. That's why we keep the original."
- 5 Believability test + bank it (1m).** Show the orange fill behind the new cutout: the edge stays clean. Group the cutout layer with its mask, name the group `SUBJECT`, leave the original photo hidden beneath, save as `composite-working.psd`.

◆ LAB: A COMPOSITE-READY CUTOUT (24 MIN)

Learners cut out their own subject (portrait, product, or pet on a plain-ish background) or `labs/module-4/practice/l11-figure-on-green.png`, following Steps 1–4 of the guided build, and save `composite-working.psd`. Fast finishers move on to `l11-pet-on-blue-wall.png` (fur edge). Full spec in `labs/module-4/README.md`.

Definition of done (the lesson's checklist): subject on its own layer with a mask (background hidden, not deleted); hair soft and natural; no colored fringe against a saturated test background; original kept as a hidden backup; group named `SUBJECT` and saved.

Circulate for: Output To still on "Selection" or "Layer Mask" (Decontaminate grays those out, so check the box is actually ticked); people painting a normal brush on hair; people judging the edge at 25% zoom.

◆ BEGINNER MISTAKES TO PRE-EMPT

- ◆ **Over-brushing:** running the Refine Edge Brush along a jaw or shoulder turns crisp detail to mush. Hair and fur only.
- ◆ **Expecting the brush to invent hair:** it rebuilds strands at the edge; it cannot recover hair the original selection missed. If a big clump is gone, go back and fix the selection first.
- ◆ **Smooth/Feather cranked up** to "fix" a jagged edge: the whole outline goes soft and looks pasted. Near 0 on hair.
- ◆ **Deleting the background** instead of masking it, or deleting the original layer. Keep both.
- ◆ **Skipping decontamination** because the cutout "looks fine" on the original background. It always looks fine there. Test against a saturated color.

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

- ◆ **Fast learners (if time / homework):** the solo variation: cut out the fur subject (`l11-pet-on-blue-wall.png`), test against three different colored fills, then zoom to 200% and inspect the hair edge pixel by pixel. Challenge: curly hair, fur, or a glass object from their own photos.
- ◆ **Struggling learners:** switch them to `l11-figure-on-green.png` (built to cut cleanly), set View to Overlay for them, and reduce the task to three moves: Select Subject, tick Decontaminate, Output To New Layer with Layer Mask. Hair refinement can come later.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING (WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK) + JOURNAL

Answers: **Q1 B)** edge pixels carry color from the old background; **Q2 B)** it replaces the old background's color in the edge pixels; **Q3 C)** New Layer with Layer Mask; **Q4 B)** wispy hair and fur only; **Q5 A)** drop a saturated colored layer behind the cutout; **Q6 C)** `Ctrl+Alt+R` / `⌘+⌥+R`. Full explanations in the Answer Key. Journal prompt (write now if time, otherwise homework): *Before today, would you have noticed a fringe on a cutout? Note one composite in the wild (an ad, a meme, a movie poster) where the cutout betrays itself.*

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Diagnose why a composite looks "pasted" by checking brightness, color, and contrast
- ◆ Match the subject to the scene with clipped adjustment layers
- ◆ Pull the scene's color into the subject with Curves and Color Balance
- ◆ Use a clipping mask so each adjustment affects only the subject

◆ TEACHING SEQUENCE + LIVE-DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 **Frame: speak the scene's language (3m).** Say: "Every object in a real scene is lit by the same sources, so they share an accent: the same warmth, brightness range, softness. A pasted subject speaks with a foreign accent." Write on the board: **1 Brightness • 2 Color • 3 Contrast**. Say: "In that order. Brightness alone is usually eighty percent of the 'pasted' feeling."
- 2 **Bring in the scene (2m).** In `composite-working.psd`: File ► Place Embedded → `l12-scene-sunset.jpg`, press Enter to accept, drag its layer below the `SUBJECT` group.
- 3 **Position and size (2m).** Right-click the `SUBJECT` group ► **Convert to Smart Object**. `Ctrl+T` / `⌘+T`, scale to a believable size. Say: "Where would this person actually stand? Feet on the ground, not floating."
- 4 **Brightness first (4m).** Add a Curves adjustment layer above the subject, clip it with `Ctrl+Alt+G` / `⌘+⌥+G` (or `Alt+⌥`-click the line between the layers). Point at the indent and bent arrow (↵) and the underlined name of the layer it clips to. Drag the curve down until the subject sits in the scene's brightness range. Say: "Squint. Squinting hides detail and shows brightness mismatches."
- 5 **Color temperature (4m).** Add a clipped Color Balance; push toward red and yellow in the midtones and highlights for the sunset. Then switch Tone to Shadows and nudge slightly cooler. Say: "Warm light usually means cool shadows. Warm everything evenly and the subject looks dipped in orange."
- 6 **Contrast and saturation (2m).** If the scene is soft and hazy, flatten the subject's contrast a touch with the clipped Curves. Add a clipped Hue/Saturation and pull Saturation down a few points.
- 7 **Squint-and-flick (1m).** Toggle all clipped layers off and on. Say: "The 'off' version should now look obviously wrong. If it does, you matched well."

◆ LAB: MATCH THE SUBJECT (24 MIN)

Learners place a background (their own, or `labs/module-4/practice/l12-scene-sunset.jpg`) under their L11 cutout and follow Steps 1–4: Smart Object + scale, clipped Curves (brightness), clipped Color Balance (temperature), clipped Curves/Hue/Saturation (contrast and saturation). Fast finishers repeat the match on `l12-scene-overcast.jpg`.

Definition of done: subject sized and positioned believably (feet on the ground); brightness matches nearby scene elements; lit side carries the scene's color and shadows are not over-warmed; contrast and saturation match; every adjustment is clipped, leaving the background untouched.

Circulate for: adjustment layers without the ↵ hook (the background changed color too); adjustments placed *below* the subject; subjects that are simply too large for the scene.

◆ BEGINNER MISTAKES TO PRE-EMPT

- ◆ **Forgetting to clip.** The most common error of the day. Tell them: "If your sky changed color, you forgot to clip." Have them check for the ↵ on every adjustment.
- ◆ **Starting with color.** People love the Color Balance sliders and ignore brightness. Enforce the order.
- ◆ **Scaling the raw layer many times** before converting to a Smart Object, softening it. Convert first, then scale.
- ◆ **"Dipped in orange."** Warming the whole subject evenly. Cool the shadows a touch.
- ◆ **Clipping confusion:** a clipping mask is not a layer mask. Clipping restricts an adjustment to the shape of the layer directly below; a layer mask hides parts of a layer (black hides, white reveals).

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

- ◆ **Fast learners (if time / homework):** match the same cutout into both the sunset and the overcast scene and line them up; try the hard case (`l12-subject-indoor-warm.png` , a tungsten-lit subject, into daylight); add the **light wrap**: duplicate the background (`Ctrl/⌘+J`), drag it above the subject and clip it, Gaussian Blur roughly 20–40 px, Screen or Soft Light at low opacity, black mask, paint white only along the edges facing the light. Local matches: a second clipped set masked to just the clothing or just the skin.
- ◆ **Struggling learners:** brightness only. One clipped Curves, squint, done. That alone does most of the work; add color when brightness is right. Give them a shortcut card: `Ctrl+Alt+G / ⌘+⌘+G` = clip.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING (WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK) + JOURNAL

Answers: **Q1** A) brightness, then color, then contrast; **Q2** C) it affects only the layer directly below; **Q3** B) `Ctrl/⌘+Alt/⌘+G`; **Q4** B) add a touch of cooler color to the shadow side; **Q5** A) so resizing never degrades it; **Q6** C) sample a neutral surface / read highlights and shadows. Journal prompt: *Which of the three (brightness, color, contrast) was hardest for your eye to judge?*

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Anchor a subject with a contact shadow and a soft cast shadow
- ◆ Add depth with atmospheric perspective (haze)
- ◆ Tie everything together with a single unifying grade
- ◆ Save a layered master and export a flattened, finished, believable composite

◆ TEACHING SEQUENCE + LIVE-DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 **Frame: object, space, whole (3m).** Say: "Three cues convince the eye. Shadow ties the object to the ground. Depth, haze, restores the space. One grade over everything makes it feel shot on one camera." Point out the spiral: masks (Module 1), Curves (Module 2), shadow painting that is really dodge and burn (Module 3). Draw the finishing stack on the board: **grade on top · haze · SUBJECT · contact shadow · cast shadow · background.**
- 2 **Contact shadow (5m).** New layer *below* the subject, name it **Contact Shadow**. Soft black brush, low opacity, paint a small dark pool right where the feet touch the ground. Say: "Darkest and tightest at the contact point. This layer never gets blurred."
- 3 **Cast shadow (5m).** Second new layer just below Contact Shadow, name it **Cast Shadow**. Point at the scene's existing shadows first. Say: "The sun here is on the right, so the shadow falls to the left. One light, one shadow direction." Paint a longer, softer shadow away from the light, lowering brush opacity as you move outward, then Filter ► Blur ► Gaussian Blur on this layer only.
- 4 **Atmosphere (2m).** Only if the subject sits in the mid or far distance: a low-opacity soft layer of the scene's haze color, masked to the distance. Say: "Haze is a whisper. If you can see it, it's too strong."
- 5 **Unify (3m).** At the very top of the stack, a Color Lookup or gentle Curves for one shared mood. Vignette: new layer, big soft black brush on the corners, lower the layer's opacity until the edges quietly darken.
- 6 **Save and export (1m).** File ► Save the layered master (do not flatten). File ► Export ► Export As, choose JPG. Say: "Export flattens automatically. Your .psd stays fully layered."

◆ LAB: GROUND, DEPTH, GRADE (32 MIN), MODULE 4 DELIVERABLE

Learners finish their L12 composite with Steps 1–4 and export a JPG. Fast finishers use **labs/module-4/practice/l13-scene-hard-sun.jpg** (hard sun) against **l12-scene-overcast.jpg** (soft light) to compare shadows.

Definition of done: a dark, tight contact shadow where the subject meets the ground; a softer, blurred cast shadow on its own layer falling the same way as the scene's other shadows; distance reads through subtle

atmosphere (where relevant); one unifying grade over the whole stack; layered master saved and JPG exported.

Circulate for: shadows painted *inside* the SUBJECT Smart Object or above it; the Gaussian Blur run on the contact-shadow layer; the unifying grade clipped to the subject (it must sit unclipped at the top); learners who flattened and saved over their master.

◆ BEGINNER MISTAKES TO PRE-EMPT

- ◆ **Wrong shadow direction.** Always check the background's own shadows before painting. Sun high-right means the shadow falls low-left.
- ◆ **Uniform shadow.** One flat gray blob looks fake. Darkest and sharpest at contact, softer and lighter as it travels.
- ◆ **Heavy haze and heavy grade.** Both are cohesion tools, not drama tools. If the grade is doing the heavy lifting, the L12 match needs work.
- ◆ **Flattening the master.** Save the .psd first; Export As handles the flattened JPG.

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

- ◆ **Fast learners (if time / homework):** finish one composite under hard light and one under soft light and compare shadows (hard light: sharp, dark; soft light: faint, fuzzy); point the shadow the wrong way on purpose, then fix it; grade the same composite warm and golden, then cool and moody. Master's touch: **reflected light**, a little bounced scene color (green grass under a chin) on the shadow side.
- ◆ **Struggling learners:** contact shadow + unifying grade only, then save and export. The contact shadow is the single strongest cue; a composite with just that and one grade is a legitimate deliverable. Add the cast shadow if time allows.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING (WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK) + JOURNAL

Answers: **Q1 B)** a contact shadow; **Q2 A)** so it can be blurred without softening the contact point; **Q3 C)** low-left; **Q4 B)** hazier, lighter, lower in contrast; **Q5 A)** at the very top of the stack, over everything; **Q6 B)** save the layered .psd, then Export As JPG. Journal prompt: *Of shadow, atmosphere, and grade, which made the biggest difference to your composite?*

GALLERY & CRITIQUE PROTOCOL (13 MIN)

- 1 Each learner puts their exported JPG full-screen for about 45 seconds (in a large room, a handful of volunteers).
- 2 The room squints together and answers three questions aloud: **Where is the light coming from? Do the shadows agree? Does the subject pop out or melt in?**
- 3 The maker names one thing they are proud of and one thing they would fix next.

- 4 Keep feedback specific and kind: "the contact shadow sells it; the cast shadow could be softer at the tip" rather than "looks fake."

CLOSING THE MODULE

MODULE 4 WRAP-UP (5 MIN)

Recap the arc: **a fringe-free cutout → a subject matched to the scene's light → a grounded, graded, single photograph.** Everyone should leave with a layered `composite-working.psd` and an exported JPG.

Encourage: "You just made an image that never existed look like one frame. That took every module so far."

Preview Module 5: "Next session we design: type, shapes, and layout, as you build a poster. Bring your composite; it can be the poster's hero image."

Module 5 — Design & Type

How to teach the three lessons that take learners from photo editing into design: a clear type hierarchy, crisp vector shapes and the Pen, and a polished poster finished with layer styles and exported correctly for screen and print. This module completes the Practitioner tier.

3 lessons

3 h session incl. break

Lessons L14–L16

Level Practitioner

Maps to Session 6

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

- Same rhythm as every module: **Frame** → **Demo** → **Lab** → **Check**. All three lessons build **one file**, **poster-working.psd**, from blank canvas to exported poster.
- This is a mindset shift.** Modules 0–4 were raster photo work; this module is design and vector. Name the shift out loud, and lean on the lesson's promise: design is a set of rules, not a talent.
- Teal** = hands-on, **amber** = watch-outs. In Module 5 the watch-outs are *taste traps* (timid titles, too many fonts, too many effects) and one real tool hurdle: the Pen.
- Shortcuts are given as **Windows** / **Mac**. Tool letters: Type T, Pen P, Shape tools U, Path Selection / Direct Selection A, Move V.

THE #1 RISK OF SESSION 6: THE PEN TOOL WALL

L15 is where confident learners suddenly feel clumsy. The Pen places anchor points; it does not draw where you drag. Teach the **two-move rule** (click for corners, click-and-drag for curves) before anyone touches a real shape, and hand out **l15-pen-practice.png**, which has the anchor points marked. Tell the room up front: "Your first curves will be lumpy. Everyone's are. The Pen rewards practice more than any tool in Photoshop."

SESSION 6 AGENDA (3 HOURS)

CLOCK	SEGMENT	MIN	WHAT HAPPENS
0:00–0:05	Open & recap	5	Two or three Module 4 composites on screen. "Today your images get words." Show the finished-poster goal. Hand out the poster copy (l14-poster-copy.txt) or have learners write their own event.
0:05–0:08	L14 frame	3	"Type has a job." Show l14-flat-type-before.png : where does your eye go first?

CLOCK	SEGMENT	MIN	WHAT HAPPENS
0:08–0:23	L14 demo	15	New poster doc, a type layer per line, sizing by reading order, Character panel, type on a path.
0:23–0:47	L14 lab	24	Fix the hierarchy in <code>poster-working.psd</code> .
0:47–0:50	L14 check	3	Two self-check items aloud; journal prompt assigned.
0:50–0:53	L15 frame	3	"Math, not pixels." Vector vs raster.
0:53–1:09	L15 demo	16	Frame, badge with Path Operations, the Pen's two-move rule, Path mode triple duty, the scale test.
1:09–1:32	L15 lab	23	Frame, badge, one Pen shape, one path reused as a mask.
1:32–1:35	L15 check	3	Self-check items aloud; journal prompt assigned.
1:35–1:47	Break	12	Suggest a squint at each other's posters on the way out.
1:47–1:50	L16 frame	3	"Live effects." Flat vs finished.
1:50–2:08	L16 demo	18	Layer Style dialog, copy/paste styles, Smart Objects, hero image, align, then export for screen vs print.
2:08–2:42	L16 lab	34	Finish, assemble, and export the poster (screen version required in class).
2:42–2:45	L16 check	3	Self-check items aloud.
2:45–2:55	Poster gallery	10	Exported JPGs full-screen; the room names the 1st, 2nd, and 3rd thing they read.
2:55–3:00	Wrap & journal	5	Practitioner tier complete. Assign journals and the print-ready version as homework; preview Module 6 (AI & Speed).

If the room runs late, protect the L16 lab and the screen export; move the print-ready PDF (bleed, CMYK, PDF/X) to homework with the workbook's print checklist. The solo variations and "going further" extensions are **if time / homework**, listed under Differentiation.

MODULE AT A GLANCE

LESSON	TOPIC	TIME	LEARNERS LEAVE ABLE TO...
L14	Type & Hierarchy	45m	Set point and paragraph type, build a reading order with size, weight, and space, and set type on a path

LESSON	TOPIC	TIME	LEARNERS LEAVE ABLE TO...
L15	Shapes & the Pen	45m	Explain vector vs raster, build and combine shape layers, draw with the Pen, reuse a path as a selection or mask
L16	Layer Styles & the Poster	58m	Apply and reuse live layer styles, use Smart Objects, and export for screen and print

One story, one file: **words with a reading order → crisp vector structure → polish and export.**

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Set and edit text with the Type tool (point type vs paragraph type)
- ◆ Build a clear visual hierarchy with size, weight, and spacing
- ◆ Control tracking, kerning, and leading in the Character panel
- ◆ Curve text along a shape with type on a path

◆ TEACHING SEQUENCE + LIVE-DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 **Frame: type has a job (3m).** Put `l14-flat-type-before.png` on screen. Ask: "What do you read first?" (Nobody agrees: that's the problem.) Say: "Every line has a job: grab attention, give the key detail, or be the fine print. Three tools do almost all the work: **size, weight, space**. 'I have no eye for design' usually means nobody told you the rules."
- 2 **New poster (2m).** File ► New, 18 × 24 inches at 150 ppi, dark background. Save as `poster-working.psd`. Say: "We'll build this one file all session."
- 3 **Get the words down (4m).** Type tool (T), click once, type `SUMMER`. Commit with Ctrl+Enter / ⌘+Enter, Esc, or the ✓ in the options bar. Click an *empty* spot for each next line (MUSIC FESTIVAL, July 18 · Riverside Park, Live bands · Food trucks · All ages, TICKETS AT THE DOOR). Say: "Clicking on existing text edits it. Click empty canvas for a new layer. Single click = point type, for short display lines. Click-and-drag a box = paragraph type, for body text that wraps."
- 4 **Assign jobs and size boldly (3m).** Say the reading order aloud: name 1st, date and place 2nd, details 3rd, fine print last. Scale the title up until it feels uncomfortably big, then a bit more. Say: "Weak hierarchy is the most common beginner mistake. If your 1st and 2nd lines are close in size, it's too weak."
- 5 **Character panel (2m).** Window ► Character. Tighten **leading** on the two-line title so it reads as one unit; add positive **tracking** (for example +120) to the small all-caps label. Say: "Leading = between lines. Tracking = evenly across a word or line. Kerning = between one specific pair of letters."
- 6 **Type on a path (1m).** Ellipse tool, mode set to **Path** in the options bar, drag a circle. Hover the Type tool over the path until the cursor shows a wavy line, click, type `EST · 2026 · LIVE`. Drag with the Path Selection tool to slide or flip it. Say: "Upside-down on the bottom of the circle? Normal. Drag across the path to flip it."

◆ LAB: FIX THE HIERARCHY (24 MIN)

Learners build their poster text in `poster-working.psd` from `labs/module-5/practice/l14-poster-copy.txt` (or their own event), following Steps 1–4: every line its own layer, a reading order, bold sizing, deliberate leading and tracking, one accent color, and one piece of type on a path.

Definition of done (the lesson's checklist): every line is its own type layer with a clear job; the 1st line is boldly bigger; leading and tracking are set deliberately; one or two fonts and one accent color; at least one element uses type on a path.

Circulate for: all text in one layer; a title set as paragraph type in a too-small box (overflow hidden); three or more fonts; an accent color on every line.

◆ BEGINNER MISTAKES TO PRE-EMPT

- ◆ **Timid title.** The fix on most beginner posters: "make the main thing much larger."
- ◆ **Font circus.** Two fonts maximum: one characterful display font for the title, one clean font for the rest. Contrast through size and weight.
- ◆ **Paragraph type for a title.** If the box is too small the overflow is hidden, and resizing the box doesn't scale the letters. Use point type for display lines.
- ◆ **Typing into the wrong layer.** Clicking on existing text edits it. Commit first, then click empty canvas.
- ◆ **Crowding.** White space is not wasted space; it's what makes the important things feel important.

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

- ◆ **Fast learners (if time / homework):** set the same text three ways changing only size and spacing (three moods, one font, no color); recreate the hierarchy of a poster or album cover they admire; curve a tagline into a full circle around a logo; set the headline in a serif, a sans, and a script and compare the personality.
- ◆ **Struggling learners:** reduce to three lines (title, date/place, fine print) and one font. Get the size jump right first; spacing and type on a path can wait. If typing new layers keeps going wrong, have them press Esc after each line as a ritual.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING (WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK) + JOURNAL

Answers: **Q1 A)** point type; **Q2 B)** the space between lines; **Q3 C)** add positive tracking; **Q4 A)** make the main line much bigger; **Q5 B)** one or two; **Q6 C)** drag across the path with the Path Selection tool to flip it. Full explanations in the Answer Key. Journal prompt: *Did "I have no eye for design" ever apply to you? Write down the one rule that surprised you most.*

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Explain vector vs raster, and why vectors never pixelate
- ◆ Draw and combine shape layers (rectangles, ellipses, custom shapes)
- ◆ Use the Pen tool to make clean straight and curved paths
- ◆ Turn paths into shapes, selections, or masks

◆ TEACHING SEQUENCE + LIVE-DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 **Frame: math, not pixels (3m).** Say: "A photo is a grid of colored squares. Enlarge it and there are no new squares, so edges go soft or blocky. A vector is stored as instructions: 'a circle of this radius here.' Photoshop redraws it fresh at any size. Type is vector too. Photos are raster; logos, icons, frames, badges, and type should be vector."
- 2 **A frame (2m).** Rectangle tool (U), mode **Shape**. Draw a border rectangle. Options bar: Fill = none (the white box with a red slash, No Color), Stroke = a few pixels in the accent color.
- 3 **A badge with Path Operations (3m).** Draw an Ellipse shape. With that shape layer still active, open the **Path Operations** menu in the options bar and choose **Subtract Front Shape**, then draw a smaller circle. Say: "Set the operation *before* drawing the next shape. Hold **Shift** to add or **Alt**/**⌘** to subtract as you start dragging. On the default New Layer setting, the second shape lands on its own layer instead." Show the shape layer's thumbnail badge; double-click the thumbnail to recolor.
- 4 **The Pen's two-move rule (5m).** Pen (P), mode **Shape**. On `l15-pen-practice.png`: trace the lightning bolt with clicks only. Say: "Straight line: click, click." Then the leaf: click-and-drag to pull out handles. Say: "Curve: click and drag, then click and drag again. That's 90% of the Pen." Nudge an anchor and a handle with the **Direct Selection** tool (white arrow). Say: "One anchor wherever the curve changes direction, and no more."
- 5 **Paths do triple duty (2m).** Switch the Pen to **Path** mode, draw a closed path. Show it in the Paths panel as a **Work Path**, not a layer. With the Pen still active, right-click the path: Make Selection, Fill Path, Stroke Path, Create Vector Mask. Choose Make Selection, then Add Layer Mask. Say: "Straight back to Module 1. And for any shape layer, **Ctr**/**⌘**-click its thumbnail to load it as a selection."
- 6 **The scale test (1m).** Duplicate a small shape layer, right-click the copy ► **Rasterize Layer**. Scale both about 400% with **Ctr**/**⌘**+**T**; view at 100%. Say: "Just zooming won't show it: Photoshop draws both as screen pixels at high zoom. The difference appears when you resize."

◆ LAB: VECTOR ELEMENTS (23 MIN)

In `poster-working.psd`: a stroked frame with no fill, a badge from combined shapes (with the L14 type on a path around it), one custom Pen shape (a mountain, a soundwave, a leaf), one path reused as a selection or mask, and the scale test. Warm up on `labs/module-5/practice/l15-pen-practice.png` first (5 min max).

Definition of done: a vector frame with a stroke and no fill; a badge built from combined shapes; one custom Pen shape with few, clean anchor points; shape edges crisp after scaling up 400% (the rasterized copy is not); at least one path reused as a selection or mask.

Circulate for: a Pen left in Path mode when they wanted a shape (nothing appears in Layers); dozens of anchor points; frames with a solid fill covering the poster; badges on two separate layers because Path Operations was set after drawing.

◆ BEGINNER MISTAKES TO PRE-EMPT

- ◆ **Dragging the Pen like a brush.** It places points; it doesn't paint. Demonstrate the wrong way once so they recognize it.
- ◆ **Too many anchor points** = lumpy curves. Also check that handles run roughly tangent to the curve.
- ◆ **Wrong mode.** Shape mode makes a layer; Path mode makes a Work Path; Pixels mode is raster. Check the options bar first.
- ◆ **Rasterizing to "fix" something.** Rasterizing throws away crisp-at-any-size. Only for pixel edits, and keep a vector copy.

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

- ◆ **Fast learners (if time / homework):** the "Pen game" (heart, cloud, lightning bolt with as few points as possible); rebuild `l15-logo-to-rebuild.png` with Shape tools and Path Operations; trace a hard-edged subject (a bottle, a car) with the Pen instead of Select & Mask.
- ◆ **Struggling learners:** Pen straight lines only today (the mountain range or lightning bolt: clicks only). Build the frame and badge with Shape tools, which need no Pen at all. Curves become homework with the practice sheet.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING (WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK) + JOURNAL

Answers: **Q1 B)** it is stored as math and redrawn at any size; **Q2 A)** click for corners, click-and-drag for curves; **Q3 C)** too many anchor points; **Q4 B)** a Work Path in the Paths panel; **Q5 A)** scale both up about 400% and compare at 100%; **Q6 C)** with the shape layer active, before drawing the second shape. Journal prompt: *After the two-move rule, does the Pen feel less mysterious? Note the shape you found hardest to trace and why.*

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Apply layer styles (Drop Shadow, Stroke, Gradient Overlay) as live effects
- ◆ Copy, paste, and reuse styles across layers
- ◆ Use Smart Objects for logos and repeated graphics
- ◆ Assemble a poster and export correctly for print vs screen

◆ TEACHING SEQUENCE + LIVE-DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 **Frame: live effects (3m).** Say: "A layer style lives *on* a layer, not painted into it. Change the text and the shadow follows. It's the same non-destructive idea as adjustment layers and Smart Filters from Module 2, applied to effects." Then the warning: "Overdone layer styles are the fastest way to make work look dated. One or two effects usually beats five."
- 2 **Lift the title (4m).** Double-click the title layer to the right of its name to open **Layer Style**. Tick **Gradient Overlay**, pick a two-tone version of the accent. Tick **Drop Shadow** (it's at the bottom of the list), click its name to see its controls: low opacity, small distance, moderate size. Edit the title text afterward to show the effects follow live.
- 3 **Style and reuse (3m).** Give the badge a **Stroke** and a soft Drop Shadow. Right-click its fx ► **Copy Layer Style**; right-click another layer ► **Paste Layer Style**. Say: "Consistency is what makes a design feel intentional."
- 4 **Smart Objects and a hero image (3m).** File ► Place Embedded `l16-sponsor-logo.png` (it comes in as a Smart Object), scale it freely. Place a hero photo (`l16-hero-stage.jpg`), or a learner's Module 4 composite) behind the type.
- 5 **Assemble (1m).** Move tool with smart guides; even margins; squint. Say: "The title dominates, the accent points to the key action, nothing is crowded against the edges."
- 6 **Export: screen vs print (4m).** Screen: File ► Export ► Export As ► JPG (PNG if you need transparency), RGB, pixel dimensions that fit the platform. Print: Say: "First, ask the printer for their spec sheet: CMYK profile or PDF/X preset, and bleed, often 0.125 in / 3 mm per side. Photoshop has no bleed setting, so you build it in." Show Image ► Canvas Size (add the bleed on every side, extend the background into it, keep type well inside the trim), Edit ► Convert to Profile on a copy, File ► Save a Copy as Photoshop PDF with the printer's preset. Mention soft-proofing: View ► Proof Setup and View ► Proof Colors (Ctrl/⌘+Y). Say: "Keep your layered .psd as the master. Always."

◆ LAB: FINISH THE POSTER (34 MIN), MODULE 5 DELIVERABLE

Learners complete Steps 1–4 on `poster-working.psd` and export a screen version (JPG). Assets: `labs/module-5/practice/l16-hero-stage.jpg` and `l16-sponsor-logo.png`, or their own Module 4 composite and graphics. The print-ready PDF is homework unless time allows.

Definition of done (the lesson's checklist): the title has a gradient and a subtle drop shadow; a consistent style is reused (copy/paste layer style); reusable graphics are Smart Objects; effects are restrained (two or three per layer at most); everything aligned with even margins; a screen JPG exported and viewed at full size.

Circulate for: hard, black, offset drop shadows; bevel-and-glow stacks; a logo that went soft because it was placed as pixels and scaled; a flattened master.

◆ BEGINNER MISTAKES TO PRE-EMPT

- ◆ **Heavy shadow.** Lower opacity, reduce distance, raise size a little. If you can clearly see the shadow as a separate object, dial it back.
- ◆ **Styles that don't scale.** Transforming a layer doesn't resize its effects, so a stroke can look too thin or too heavy afterward. Right-click the fx ► **Scale Effects** (or Layer ► Layer Style ► Scale Effects). Image ► Image Size scales them only when Scale Styles is ticked.
- ◆ **"Print looks different."** Screens are RGB and lit; print is CMYK ink on paper and can't hit every screen color. Design in RGB, soft-proof, confirm with the printer. Neons shift most.
- ◆ **Exporting at 300 ppi for Instagram.** The ppi number does not matter on screen; pixel dimensions do.

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

- ◆ **Fast learners (if time / homework):** restyle the poster for a different mood and watch reused styles carry the change; build a matching square social version reusing the same styles and Smart Objects; over-style one copy deliberately next to the tasteful one; save a favorite title treatment as a reusable Style in the Styles panel; produce the print-ready PDF with bleed.
- ◆ **Struggling learners:** title gradient + drop shadow, one copied style, hero image behind, export JPG. That meets the core of the deliverable; Smart Object logo and print output follow as homework.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING (WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK) + JOURNAL

Answers: **Q1** C) live, re-editable effects attached to the layer; **Q2** A) right-click fx ► Copy Layer Style, then Paste Layer Style; **Q3** B) Gradient Overlay + a subtle Drop Shadow; **Q4** A) RGB, JPG or PNG, pixel dimensions for the platform; **Q5** C) Image ► Canvas Size, extending the background into the bleed; **Q6** B) Scale Effects. Journal prompt: *How does designing (type, shapes, layout) feel different from editing photos? Which did you enjoy more, and what does that tell you about where to go next?*

POSTER GALLERY PROTOCOL (10 MIN)

- 1 Each poster JPG goes full-screen for about 30 seconds (in a large room, volunteers only).

- 2 The room calls out the **1st, 2nd, and 3rd** thing they read. If they match the maker's intended order, the hierarchy works.
- 3 One question each: "Where does the accent color send my eye?"
- 4 The maker names the style they reused and one effect they removed for restraint.

CLOSING THE MODULE

MODULE 5 WRAP-UP (5 MIN): PRACTITIONER TIER COMPLETE

Recap the arc: **a planned reading order → crisp vector structure → live polish and correct export**. Every learner should leave with a layered `poster-working.psd` and an exported screen JPG. Celebrate it: "Five modules ago you were exporting your first fixed photo. You can now retouch, composite, and design." Preview Module 6: "Next session, AI & Speed: Generative Fill and Expand, then Actions and batch processing."

Module 6: AI & Speed

How to teach the three lessons of the Advanced tier: Generative Fill, Generative Expand, and automation with Actions, Batch, and droplets. The theme of the day is "power in service of craft": the generative tools make hard edits easy, the automation makes repetitive edits vanish, and your job is to keep learners thinking like editors, not button-mashers.

3 lessons

Session 7 • 3 hrs incl. break

Lessons L17–L19

Level Beginner, Advanced tier

Needs internet + credits (L17–L18)

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

- Same rhythm as every module: **Frame** → **Demo** → **Lab** → **Check**. Each lesson plan gives a demo script (what to click, what to say), the lab, the beginner mistakes to pre-empt, a check for understanding, and differentiation notes.
- **Do every demo live on the projector**, at 100% zoom where it matters (seams, artifacts). Name every click and every menu path out loud, for both Windows and Mac: **Ctr l** on Windows is **⌘** on Mac, **Alt** is **⌥**.
- **Teal** = hands-on, **amber** = watch-outs. In this module the biggest watch-outs are environmental (network, sign-in, credits) for L17–L18 and "recorded something too specific" for L19.
- Quiz answers below match the workbook's Self-checks; the Answer Key explains each one.

BEFORE SESSION 7: THE GENERATIVE READINESS CHECK

Generative Fill and Generative Expand run in Adobe's cloud. Each learner needs **a recent Photoshop, an internet connection, to be signed in to an Adobe account**, and **generative credits** (each generation spends them; the monthly allowance depends on the plan). Classroom networks and lab licenses are the usual failure points. **At least a day before**, on one room machine: sign in, make a selection, click Generative Fill, and generate once. On the day, have everyone open Photoshop and sign in during the first ten minutes, not when L17 starts.

FALLBACK PLAN IF CREDITS OR NETWORK FAIL IN THE ROOM

1. Reorder. L19 (Actions, Batch, droplets) is 100% offline. If the network is down at the start, teach L19 first and return to L17–L18 when it recovers. **2. Share.** If only some accounts have credits, pair learners: one generates, both direct the prompt and pick the variation, then swap roles for the refine step. **3. Demo + non-generative equivalents.** If nobody can generate, run the demos from the instructor machine (or a screen recording you made during your readiness check) and have learners do the same jobs with offline tools they already know: removal with the **Remove tool** or **Content-Aware Fill** (Module 1, L04), and expansion with the Crop tool dragged outward with the options bar's **Fill** set to **Content-Aware Fill** instead of Generative Expand. The workflow lesson (select, fill, cycle, refine on a layer, check the seam at 100%) survives intact; only the "describe it in words" part is lost. **4. Homework.** Assign the L17 and L18 labs as take-home work for learners with credits at home.

SESSION 7 AGENDA (3 HOURS)

CLOCK	BLOCK	MIN	WHAT HAPPENS
0:00–0:08	Open & sign-in check	8	Everyone opens Photoshop and confirms they are signed in. One-line recap of Module 5 (the finished poster). Frame the day: "generative power, then speed."
0:08–0:26	L17 Frame + demo	18	Select-then-describe model, the Contextual Task Bar, live remove + add, refine, prompts and limits, honesty note.
0:26–0:48	L17 Lab	22	Remove a distraction and add an element on <code>generative-working.psd</code> ; refine with a mask or clipped adjustment.
0:48–1:02	L18 Frame + demo	14	Crop tool with Fill: Generative Expand, uncrop, reframe to a ratio, expand in bites, the horizon test.
1:02–1:22	L18 Lab	20	Uncrop and reframe on <code>expand-working.psd</code> ; check the seam at 100%.
1:22–1:34	Break	12	Early finishers copy the L19 practice folder to their desktop and make an empty <code>L19-processed/</code> folder beside it.
1:34–1:56	L19 Frame + demo	22	Record "Web JPG 1200" live, test on a portrait file, Batch with Override Action "Save As" Commands, then Image Processor and Create Droplet.
1:56–2:36	L19 Lab	40	Record, test, batch the practice folder; build a droplet. Fast finishers: a second Action (2000 px print JPG) or an L17/L18 "Going further."

CLOCK	BLOCK	MIN	WHAT HAPPENS
2:36–2:48	Check & journal	12	Review the three Self-checks together (cold-call a few items), then the journal prompts.
2:48–3:00	Capstone homework launch	12	Show the six briefs from L20, explain the homework and the "build most of it at home" expectation (see Closing), answer questions.

Three lessons in three hours is tight, so demos stay crisp and fast finishers extend inside the lab time rather than in a separate block. If the room runs slow, shorten the check-and-journal block (learners can journal at home) and trim the L19 fast-finisher extension. Never cut the capstone homework launch: Session 8 depends on learners arriving with a chosen brief and most of their piece built.

MODULE AT A GLANCE

LESSON	TOPIC	TIME	LEARNERS LEAVE ABLE TO...
L17	Generative Fill	40m	Remove with an empty prompt, add with a short concrete prompt, and refine the generative layer
L18	Generative Expand & Reframe	34m	Uncrop a tight photo and reframe it to a new ratio with an invisible seam
L19	Actions, Batch & Droplets	62m	Record an Action, batch a folder into consistent web files, and make a droplet

The module is one story: **add and remove inside the frame → invent space outside the frame → do the routine work at scale**. L18 is "the same idea as L17, aimed at empty canvas," so let the spiral do the teaching.

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ **Remove** an object by selecting it and generating with an empty prompt
- ◆ **Add** new content by selecting an area and describing what belongs there
- ◆ Work with **generative layers** and cycle through **variations**
- ◆ Write prompts that work, and know Generative Fill's **limits**

◆ TEACHING SEQUENCE & DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 Hook (2m).** Show the lesson's before/after (sign removed, sailboat added). *Say:* "Two edits, two prompts, and not one original pixel touched. Today you learn to drive this, and to know when not to."
- 2 Mental model (3m).** Write on the board: **Select the where → describe the what → Generate → pick a variation → refine.** *Say:* "Empty prompt removes. A described prompt adds. The result is a new generative layer with its own mask, so it is one more non-destructive layer, the principle from Module 0 all over again."
- 3 Demo: the task bar (2m).** Open `l17-lake-sign.jpg`, save as `generative-working.psd`. *Click:* Lasso around the sign with a little margin. Point at the floating **Contextual Task Bar**. *Say:* "No task bar? Window ► Contextual Task Bar, or use Edit ► Generative Fill instead."
- 4 Demo: remove (3m).** *Click:* Generative Fill → leave the prompt empty → Generate. Show the new generative layer in the Layers panel and cycle the three variations. *Say:* "This is the smarter cousin of Content-Aware Fill from Module 1."
- 5 Demo: add (4m).** *Click:* a tall-ish selection over open water → Generative Fill → type `a small sailboat` → Generate. *Say:* "Want a tall thing? Make a tall selection. Selecting the right space is half the prompt." Then click Generate again for three more, to show iteration is cheap.
- 6 Demo: refine (2m).** Paint on the generative layer's mask to soften a rough edge; clip a Curves layer to it to match brightness. *Say:* "Generative is a strong start, not always a finish. Your craft finishes the job."
- 7 Prompts, limits, ethics (2m).** Concrete and short ("a wooden park bench," not "something nice to sit on"); describe the thing, not the style; tweak one or two words rather than rewriting. Limits: hands, text, small faces; very large generations; needs internet and credits; results vary. Honesty: **Content Credentials** flag AI edits; journalism, evidence, and documentary work have a line.

◆ LAB: REMOVE & ADD (22 MIN)

Learners use their own photo (a clear distraction plus some open space) or `l17-lake-sign.jpg`, saved as `generative-working.psd`. Steps 1–3 of the lesson: remove, add, blend and refine. Fast finishers take `l17-three-distractions.jpg` and remove all three, one selection at a time. See `labs/module-6/README.md`.

Circulate for: each result on its own generative layer (original Background untouched); loose selections with margin, not tight outlines; learners actually cycling variations before accepting; at least one refine move (mask, clipped adjustment, or healing on a layer).

◆ BEGINNER MISTAKES TO PRE-EMPT

- ◆ **"Generative Fill is grayed out."** Not signed in, no internet, or an old Photoshop version. Check sign-in first (if the Help menu offers "Sign In...", they are signed out); do not debug for more than two minutes, switch to the fallback plan.
- ◆ **Selection hugging the object exactly.** Removal leaves halos and edge ghosts. Loose selection, a little margin.
- ◆ **Long, stylistic prompts.** "A beautiful cinematic golden-hour yacht in watercolor style" fights the scene's light. Name the object; let the scene set the light.
- ◆ **Accepting the first variation.** Make "look at all three" a rule.
- ◆ **Blurry, low-detail result.** Selection was too large. Generate in smaller pieces, or regenerate.
- ◆ **Adding text or hands on purpose and expecting it to work.** Save this for the solo "hard prompt" experiment, framed as learning its weak spots.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING (WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK)

Answers: **Q1 B)** Select an area, then describe what should be there; **Q2 C)** Leave the prompt empty and click Generate; **Q3 A)** On a new generative layer with its own mask; **Q4 B)** "a wooden park bench"; **Q5 C)** Make a taller selection. Cold-call: "Where would you draw your line between cleaning up a photo and changing its truth?" Then 3–5 minutes for the **Learning Journal** prompt.

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

- ◆ **Fast:** the solo challenge: three removals on one busy photo, regenerate the same selection with a different prompt, one deliberately hard prompt (hands or readable text). Going further: treat a generated element as a real subject, then mask, grade, and add a shadow (Module 4).
- ◆ **Struggling:** do only Step 1 (remove) until it is solid, on the practice file with the sign. Give them the recipe card and let them repeat it on two more distractions before attempting "add."

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Extend the canvas with the Crop tool and fill the new space generatively
- ◆ Uncrop a too-tight photo to give a subject room to breathe
- ◆ Reframe a photo to a new aspect ratio for print, web, or social
- ◆ Guide the fill with an optional prompt and keep the seam invisible

◆ TEACHING SEQUENCE & DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 **Frame (2m).** Say: "Sometimes the problem is not inside the photo, it is the edges. Expand is Generative Fill aimed at the empty canvas around your image. Same layer, same variations, same optional prompt. If you understood L17, you already understand this."
- 2 **Demo: uncrop (4m).** Open `l18-tight-portrait.jpg`, save as `expand-working.psd`. Click: Crop tool (C) → options bar **Fill: Generative Expand** → drag the side handle outward past the photo. Leave the task bar prompt empty → **Generate**. Say: "The Crop tool can crop outward. Pressing Enter or the checkmark may also generate straight away with no prompt, so use the task bar when you want to type one."
- 3 **Demo: reframe to a ratio (3m).** Undo, then pick **Ratio 16:9**. Point out the box first fits *inside* the photo (which would crop it). Click: drag the handles outward until the box extends past the edges; the ratio stays locked. Generate. Say: "A vertical phone photo just became a banner, and nothing was stretched."
- 4 **Expand in bites (2m).** Show one huge expansion going vague and repetitive, then redo it in two or three smaller steps. The comparison sells the habit.
- 5 **Seam check (3m).** Zoom to 100% along the join. Run **the horizon test**: does the horizon or any strong line jump? If so, cycle variations; if none line up, select a thin strip across the seam and regenerate just that with Generative Fill (L17). Finish with a subtle clipped Curves or a whisper of the Module 4 unifying grade over the whole frame.

◆ LAB: UNCROP & REFRAME (20 MIN)

On their own cramped photo or `l18-tight-portrait.jpg`: Step 1 uncrop, Step 2 reframe to one ratio (16:9, 1:1, or 4:5), Step 3 optional prompt ("open sky," "more forest"), Step 4 hide the seam. Seam-test file: `l18-horizon-strip.jpg`. See `labs/module-6/README.md`.

Circulate for: Fill set to Generative Expand (not Background); handles dragged *past* the photo, not just a ratio chosen; horizon continuous across the seam at 100%; no stretching (circles stay round).

◆ BEGINNER MISTAKES TO PRE-EMPT

- ◆ **Choosing a ratio and pressing Enter.** The box sits inside the photo, so Photoshop crops instead of expanding. Ratio sets only the shape; you still drag outward.
- ◆ **Fill left on Background.** The new space fills with the background color (flat white or black). Check the options bar before dragging.
- ◆ **One giant leap.** Smearly, repetitive margins. Expand partway, generate, repeat.
- ◆ **Using Free Transform to "widen" the photo.** That stretches the subject. Expand invents new space instead.
- ◆ **Judging at fit-to-screen.** Seams hide at small zoom. The check happens at 100%.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING (WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK)

Answers: **Q1 A)** Generative Fill aimed at empty canvas around the photo; **Q2 C)** Drag the crop handles outward past the photo; **Q3 B)** Expand in smaller steps, generating each time; **Q4 B)** A horizon or strong line that jumps at the seam; **Q5 A)** Continue the existing scene. Journal prompt: when does room to breathe improve a photo, and when does it dilute a shot that was strong because it was tight?

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

- ◆ **Fast:** one vertical photo to three versions (1:1, 16:9, 9:16) by expanding; or expand a portrait for headroom and drop a title into it (Module 5 type). Going further: expand, then generatively add a new element into the new space.
- ◆ **Struggling:** uncrop one side only with an empty prompt, then do the horizon test. Skip ratios until that feels easy.

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Record, play, and edit an Action
- ◆ Run an Action across a folder with Batch
- ◆ Resize and convert a whole shoot with the Image Processor
- ◆ Turn an Action into a drag-and-drop droplet

◆ TEACHING SEQUENCE & DEMO SCRIPT

- 1 **Frame (2m).** Say: "Generative tools make hard edits easy. Automation makes repetitive edits vanish. The rule of the lesson: if you do it more than twice, record it. Automate the boring, keep the creative."
- 2 **Setup (1m).** Show the two folders: `l19-input/` (the practice batch files) and an empty `l19-processed/` beside it. Open Window ► Actions.
- 3 **Demo: record (8m).** Open `l19-batch-01.jpg`. Click: new Set "Export Web" → new Action "Web JPG 1200" → **Record**. Then, narrating each step as it appears in the panel:
 - 1 Edit ► Convert to Profile → destination **sRGB IEC61966-2.1**
 - 2 File ► Automate ► **Fit Image** → 1200 × 1200 px. Say: "Fit Image fits the long edge for landscape and portrait alike. Image Size would record a fixed width, which goes wrong on portrait files."
 - 3 File ► **Place Embedded** → `l19-watermark.png`, position it, commit
 - 4 Layer ► **Flatten Image**. Say: "Current Photoshop only offers JPEG in Save As for a file without extra layers."
 - 5 File ► Save As → JPEG, quality 8 to 10 (0–12 scale), into `l19-processed/`; then close the filePress **Stop**. Show the six recorded steps (Convert to Profile, Fit Image, Place, Flatten, Save, Close).
- 4 **Demo: test on one file (3m).** Open `l19-batch-02.jpg` (a portrait file on purpose), select the Action, press **Play**. Say: "Always test on an odd file before trusting a batch. If a step misbehaves, delete just that step and re-record it."
- 5 **Demo: Batch (5m).** File ► Automate ► Batch. Set and Action; Source = `l19-input/`; Destination = `l19-processed/`; tick **Override Action "Save As" Commands**. Say: "Without this tick, Batch saves wherever you saved during recording, not where you told it." Also tick **Suppress color profile warnings** and set Errors to **Log Errors to File** so one bad file does not stop the run. OK, and watch.
- 6 **Demo: Image Processor & droplet (3m).** File ► Scripts ► **Image Processor**: a folder to sRGB JPGs with no recording. File ► Automate ► **Create Droplet**: save it to the desktop, then drag a folder onto it. Say:

"The droplet launches Photoshop for you, so Photoshop must be installed, but you never touch a menu."

◆ LAB: RECORD & BATCH (40 MIN)

Learners copy `labs/module-6/practice/l19-input/` to their desktop with an empty `l19-processed/` beside it, then: record "Web JPG 1200," test on a portrait file, batch the folder, and create a droplet. Checklist in the workbook. Fast finishers: a second Action "Print JPG 2000" and a batch comparison; or the Image Processor on the same folder.

Circulate for: Record actually pressed (the dot is red) before the first step; Fit Image, not Image Size; Flatten before Save As; Override ticked in Batch; every output in `l19-processed/` at 1200 px on the long edge with the watermark; the input folder unchanged.

◆ BEGINNER MISTAKES TO PRE-EMPT

- ◆ **Forgetting to press Stop**, so browsing and fixing mistakes get recorded too. Watch the panel: if the dot is red, it is recording.
- ◆ **Recording Image Size with a fixed width.** Portrait outputs come out 1200 px wide and very tall. Replace the step with Fit Image.
- ◆ **Save As shows no JPEG option.** The watermark layer is still there. Flatten first (the step must be in the Action).
- ◆ **Batch output lands in the wrong folder or overwrites.** Override Action "Save As" Commands was not ticked.
- ◆ **Batch stops on one file.** An unexpected color mode or a missing profile. Suppress warnings, log errors to a file, and look at the log.
- ◆ **Pointing Destination at the input folder.** Originals must stay untouched: always a separate processed folder.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING (WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK)

Answers: **Q1 B)** A recording of steps you can replay; **Q2 C)** Fit Image fits the long edge on any orientation; **Q3 A)** Tick Override Action "Save As" Commands; **Q4 C)** Layer ► Flatten Image; **Q5 B)** Image Processor; **Q6 A)** An Action saved as a drag-and-drop app. Journal prompt: three repetitive tasks in your own workflow an Action could eat.

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

- ◆ **Fast:** second Action (2000 px print JPG), droplet on the desktop, Image Processor comparison ("when is it quicker than a full Action?"). Going further: add a Curves grade step to an Action.
- ◆ **Struggling:** record a two-step Action first (Convert to Profile + Fit Image), play it on one file, then add the watermark, flatten, and save steps by selecting the last step and clicking Record again to append. Batch only after single-file play works.

CLOSING THE MODULE

MODULE 6 WRAP-UP + CAPSTONE HOMEWORK (LAST 24 MIN OF THE SESSION)

Recap the arc: **add and remove inside the frame → invent space outside it → do the routine at scale**. Then set up Session 8, the Capstone, which has no new tools.

Homework (hand out now), in two parts:

- 1. Plan it (first evening).** Read L20 "Choose Your Brief & Plan" and do its guided build: choose a brief from the L20 table, write the one-line brief sentence, collect 5 to 10 references, make a rough moodboard (3 to 5 colors, one or two fonts, a thumbnail layout), write the skill map, and set up the Photoshop document for the destination.
- 2. Build most of it (before Session 8).** Read L21 "Studio Session: Build It Well" and build the piece at home, following its habits (block in first, name and group as you go, snapshots and versioned saves). Say it plainly: **"Session 8 is not enough time to build a capstone from scratch. Plan to arrive with the piece about 70 to 80% done. The studio block is for finishing, fixing, and getting help, and the second half of the session is presentations."**

Learners bring the working `.psd`, the plan, and any assets. Learners without their own photos can use the backup assets in `labs/module-7/practice/` or free-license sources (Pexels, Unsplash) after checking the license. Remind them that a finished piece at 80% of the dream beats an abandoned masterpiece, and invite them to email or message you their one-line brief midweek if they want a quick sanity check.

Module 7: Capstone

How to run the final session: one self-directed portfolio piece, taken from brief to presented work. There are no new tools. Your job shifts from demonstrator to studio coach: protect learners' time, unblock them fast, keep scope realistic, and run a presentation and critique that is honest, kind, and specific.

3 lessons

Session 8 • 3 hrs incl. break

Lessons L20–L22

Format studio + critique

Most of the build is homework

HOW TO USE THIS GUIDE

- **The capstone spans two sessions.** It is launched at the end of Session 7 (Module 6) as homework: learners read L20 and plan, then read L21 and build most of the piece at home. Session 8 is a quick plan review, a studio block for finishing and getting help, and presentations with structured peer critique.
- **Say this plainly, twice** (at the Session 7 launch and in any midweek message): "Session 8 is not enough time to build a capstone from scratch. Arrive with your piece about 70 to 80% done. The studio block is for finishing, fixing, and getting help."
- **Teal** = hands-on, **amber** = watch-outs. In this module the risks are scope (too ambitious), stalling (no plan), and file chaos (unnamed layers, no saves).
- Quiz answers below match the workbook's Self-checks. L20 and L21 quizzes are homework; L22's is done after the session or skimmed during the close.

GENERATIVE FEATURES IN THE CAPSTONE

Some briefs (product hero shot, surreal composite) invite Generative Fill or Expand. These need internet, an Adobe sign-in, and generative credits. Tell learners to do generative steps **at home, before Session 8**, and never to plan a piece that depends on generating in class. If credits run out, the offline equivalents from Module 6 (Remove tool, Content-Aware Fill, Crop outward with Fill: Content-Aware Fill) plus compositing skills from Module 4 cover almost every brief. Any generative content should be disclosed in the artist statement where honesty matters.

BEFORE SESSION 8

- **End of Session 7:** launch the homework (see the Module 6 guide's Closing). Show the six briefs, the one-line brief template, and the "70 to 80% done" expectation.

- ◆ **Midweek (optional but powerful):** ask learners to send you their one-line brief. Reply with one sentence: a green light, or a scope trim ("Great. Make it one poster, not a series of three").
- ◆ **Room prep:** a shared folder (or USB drive) for delivery files, the projector machine able to open JPG/PNG/PDF, a visible timer, sticky notes or cards in three colors for help flags, and printed rubric cards (the L22 table) for reviewers.
- ◆ **Presentation order:** draft it before class and put it on the board, so no one spends the studio block dreading "who goes first." Put a confident learner first.

SESSION 8 AGENDA (3 HOURS)

CLOCK	BLOCK	MIN	WHAT HAPPENS
0:00–0:20	Plan review (L20)	20	Welcome (2). Pairs: each learner reads their one-line brief, shows the moodboard and current file; the partner answers "What do you expect this to look like?" (4 each, 8 total). You walk the room and build the triage list (red / yellow / green, see below). Learners write their studio goal in the workbook (5). Recap the timeline on the board (5).
0:20–1:50	Studio block (L21)	90	5 min launch (studio habits, help flags, timed cues), 75 min finishing with circulation, last 10 min ship prep (L22 Steps 1 and 3): export the delivery file into the shared folder, write the two-sentence statement, optional mockup.
1:50–2:02	Break	12	You load delivery files on the projector machine in presentation order. Learners stretch; no more editing.
2:02–2:52	Presentations + peer critique (L22)	50	The structured protocol below: about 4 minutes per learner for up to 11 learners; pods for larger groups.
2:52–3:00	Course close	8	"Where to go next" paths, the one idea to keep, final journal prompt (to finish at home), thank-you and celebration.

The presentation block is fixed; protect it. If the plan review runs long, take the time from the studio block, not from presentations. If many learners arrive under 50% done, see "If the room arrives behind" below.

MODULE AT A GLANCE

LESSON	TOPIC	WHERE	LEARNERS LEAVE ABLE TO...
L20	Choose Your Brief & Plan	home + 20m	Write a one-line brief, build a moodboard and skill map, and set up the document for its destination

LESSON	TOPIC	WHERE	LEARNERS LEAVE ABLE TO...
L21	Studio Session: Build It Well	home + 90m	Build big to small in a named, grouped, color-labeled, versioned file
L22	Present & Ship	50m + cclose	Export for the destination, present in context, critique with a rubric, and plan what to learn next

The module is one story: **brief before brush → a tidy file is a fast file → done is a decision.**

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Choose a capstone brief that plays to their strengths and interests
- ◆ Define the goal, audience, and constraints before touching Photoshop
- ◆ Gather references and build a quick moodboard
- ◆ Map the skills and layer strategy the piece will need

◆ LAUNCHING IT (LAST MINUTES OF SESSION 7)

- 1 **Brief before brush.** Say: "Before you open Photoshop, answer three questions on paper: What is it for? Who is it for? What does it look like? People who feel they have no eye for design usually skipped this step."
- 2 **The six briefs.** Show the L20 table: movie/event poster (Modules 4–5), surreal composite (Module 4), retouched portrait (Modules 2–3), old photo restoration (Modules 1–3), product hero shot (Modules 4 and 6), brand mini-kit (Modules 5–6). Say: "Pick the one that makes you slightly nervous in a good way."
- 3 **The template.** Write it on the board: "A [what] for [who], to be seen [where], that feels [three adjectives]." Read the lesson's example: "A gig poster for a local band, to be seen printed on a wall, that feels loud, retro, and warm."
- 4 **Calibrate ambition.** Say: "One notch of stretch, not ten. A finished, polished piece at 80% of your dream idea beats an abandoned masterpiece every time."

◆ PLAN REVIEW IN SESSION 8 (20 MIN)

In pairs, each learner shows the one-line brief, moodboard (3 to 5 colors, one or two fonts, a thumbnail layout), skill map (moves tagged by module), and current file. The partner answers the lesson's question: "What do you expect this to look like?" If the answer matches the brief, the plan communicates.

Triage as you walk: Red = no plan or under 30% built; yellow = built but stuck on a specific skill; green = finishing and polishing. Write initials in three columns on your sheet. This list drives the first circulation round.

◆ WATCH-OUTS

- ◆ **No brief chosen.** Give a 60-second decision: point at the table, set a timer, commit. Then scope it down with a real constraint from the lesson (square format, two-color palette, a time limit).
- ◆ **A "back pocket" of alternatives.** The lesson says commit. Two half-built pieces present worse than one finished one.

- ◆ **Document set up wrong for the destination.** Print: Print preset, real-world size, 300 ppi (convert to CMYK for the printer at export, Module 5). Web/social: pixel size for the platform, RGB. Check this during the review; it is cheap to fix now and painful later.
- ◆ **Moodboard as a copy list.** References are for feeling and direction, not things to copy.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING (WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK)

Answers: **Q1 A)** What is it for, who is it for, what does it look like; **Q2 B)** the gig poster sentence; **Q3 A)** palette, one or two fonts, rough layout; **Q4 B)** Print preset, real-world size, 300 ppi; **Q5 B)** one notch, not ten. Journal: reread the Module 0 entry; does the chosen brief connect to it?

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

- ◆ **Confident learners:** add a real constraint (square format, a two-color palette, a 30-minute limit on one stage) or a client-style audience.
- ◆ **Hesitant learners:** steer to old photo restoration (use `l21-backup-old-photo.jpg`) or a retouched portrait: clear "done," familiar skills, no blank canvas.

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Build in the right order: block in big, refine small
- ◆ Keep a complex file organized with named, grouped, color-labeled layers
- ◆ Protect work with snapshots and versioned saves
- ◆ Use a habit of stepping back to judge the whole piece

◆ STUDIO LAUNCH (5 MIN, AT THE PROJECTOR)

- 1 **The studio loop.** Block in → refine big to small → step back → refine again → finish and tidy. *Say:* "Stepping back is a step, not a break."
- 2 **File habits, shown once.** Select layers, `Ctrl/⌘ + G` to group, double-click the group name to rename it (BACKGROUND, SUBJECT, TYPE, GRADE), right-click the group's eye icon to pick a color label. In `Window ▶ History`, click the camera icon (Create New Snapshot), or `Alt/⌘`-click it to name the snapshot. *Say:* "History, snapshots included, clears when you close the file. Save versions too: `capstone_v1.psd`, `_v2`."
- 3 **Help flags.** Every learner puts a card on top of the monitor: **green** = working, **yellow** = question when you are free, **red** = blocked. *Say:* "Red means you have been stuck for five minutes. Do not sit on a red for longer than that."
- 4 **Timed cues.** Announce them now so nobody is surprised: step-back cue, "stop adding, start finishing" cue, and the export deadline.

◆ CIRCULATION & CHECK-IN PROTOCOL (75 MIN WORKING + 10 MIN SHIP PREP)

- 1 **Round 1 (0:25–0:45): reds first.** Visit every red from the triage list, 3 minutes max each. Goal: a scoped-down, finishable target for today ("Drop the second figure. Finish the sky, the subject, and the title"). Then yellows.
- 2 **Round 2 (0:45–1:20): everyone.** A 2 to 3 minute check-in with each learner using the same four prompts: "Show me your brief." · "What should I see first?" (focal point) · "What is your next move?" · **file health:** are layers named and grouped, is there a snapshot or a saved version? Leave each learner with one concrete next step.
- 3 **Answer yellow and red flags between check-ins.** Keep hands off the mouse: guide verbally ("Open the History panel. Which snapshot is before the problem?"). If three or more learners are stuck on the same skill, call a **5-minute clinic** at the projector for those learners only.

- 4 **Whole-room cue at 0:55: step back.** "Zoom to fit, squint, then View ► Flip Horizontal. It flips only the view; choose it again to flip back. Does it still serve the brief? Is the focal point winning?"
- 5 **Whole-room cue at 1:20: stop adding, start finishing.** "No new elements now. Unifying grade over everything, a 100% pass for stray artifacts, name and group anything unnamed, save `capstone_final.psd`."
- 6 **Ship prep (1:40–1:50).** Every learner exports a delivery file (JPG or PNG in sRGB for screen; print pieces also export a screen JPG for the projector), names it `firstname-capstone.jpg`, and copies it to the shared folder. Then the two-sentence statement in the workbook. Optional if time allows: place the export into a mockup (see L22).

Track it: tick each learner's name when they have had a Round 2 check-in and again when their file lands in the shared folder. At 1:45, personally chase anyone without a tick.

◆ WATCH-OUTS

- ◆ **Polishing an eyelash before the layout works.** Ask "Is the composition decided?" If not, back to block-in.
- ◆ **"Layer 12 copy 3."** Name as you go, not at the end. Make naming and grouping a condition of your check-in: you will help once the stack is named.
- ◆ **The mid-project dip.** "It looks worse than before" is normal; it is the middle. Jump to an earlier snapshot or version, step back, reread the brief.
- ◆ **Huge, slow file.** Save a full layered version first, then merge or flatten finished sections in a working copy; Edit ► Purge if history is eating memory. (Converting groups to Smart Objects tidies the stack but usually does not shrink the file.)
- ◆ **New generative experiments in class.** Credits and network are not guaranteed; steer to finishing with offline tools.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING (WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK)

Answers: **Q1** B) block in, then refine big to small; **Q2** A) right-click the group's eye icon and pick a color; **Q3** B) History clears on close, so also save versions; **Q4** B) it flips only the view; **Q5** A) save a full layered version, then merge in a working copy. Journal: which skill did the capstone lean on most, and which one needs more practice?

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

- ◆ **Ahead of schedule:** the "Going further": pick a snapshot, use the History panel's Create new document from current state button, and export that as a process image. Or build a second context (phone screen as well as a framed print).
- ◆ **Behind:** agree a "minimum presentable" version: the focal element finished, one unifying grade, clean edges at 100%. Unfinished side elements get hidden, not rushed.

◆ OBJECTIVES

- ◆ Export the piece correctly for its destination
- ◆ Present it in context with mockups so it reads as finished work
- ◆ Write a short artist statement and critique the piece with a rubric
- ◆ Build a portfolio entry and know where to grow next

◆ FRAMING THE CRITIQUE (2 MIN, BEFORE THE FIRST PRESENTER)

- 1 Say: "A piece, not a file. Presenting, critiquing, and shipping are what turn pixels into work people respond to. Done is a decision, and today everyone decides."
- 2 **Norms** on the board: critique the work, not the person · be specific (point at the pixels) · judge against the **brief**, not your taste · the presenter listens and says thank you, no defending · kind is not the same as vague.
- 3 Hand out the **rubric cards** (the L22 table): Focal point · Light & color · Edges & masks · Type (if any) · Believability · The squint test.

◆ PRESENTATION & STRUCTURED PEER CRITIQUE PROTOCOL (ABOUT 4 MIN PER LEARNER)

- 1 **Present (90 s).** The presenter shows the final (in its mockup if they made one), reads the two-sentence statement (what it is and who it is for; one interesting decision and why), and shows one process image or before/after if they have it.
- 2 **Squint test (15 s).** The whole room squints at the projector. You ask: "What do you see first?" Two or three people call it out. Does it match the presenter's intended focal point?
- 3 **Two reviewers (90 s).** Assigned in advance: the next two people in the presentation order. Each opens with the lesson's outside-eyes question ("The first thing I notice is... and what confused me was..."), then picks **one rubric row** and gives **one glow** (what works, specifically) and **one grow** (phrased "I wonder if..." or "What if you tried...").
- 4 **Presenter notes (15 s).** The presenter writes the grow in the workbook's critique box and says thank you. Instructor adds at most one sentence, and only if the reviewers missed something important.

Group size: 50 minutes fits about 11 learners at 4 minutes each with transitions. For **12 or more**, split into pods of 4 to 5 around a laptop, with a printed rubric and a pod timekeeper; run the same protocol in parallel for 30 minutes while you float, then each pod nominates one piece for a whole-room showcase (15 minutes). For very small groups (under 6), give each presenter 7 to 8 minutes and let everyone review.

◆ WATCH-OUTS

- ◆ **Apologizing before showing** ("It's not finished, I ran out of time..."). Coach it out in advance: start with the statement, not the excuse.
- ◆ **Reviewers who only say "I love it."** Ask "Which rubric row, and what exactly on screen?"
- ◆ **Harsh or taste-based critique.** Redirect to the brief: "Does it do what the brief says for that audience?"
- ◆ **The layered .psd sent as the delivery file.** The master stays safe; the delivery is JPG or PNG in sRGB for screen, or a print PDF at 300 ppi in CMYK with bleed to the printer's spec.
- ◆ **Undisclosed generative content.** Ask presenters to mention generative edits in the statement where honesty matters; Content Credentials can travel with the file.

◆ COURSE CLOSE (8 MIN)

- 1 **Where to go next.** Show the four paths: photo retoucher (Modules 2–3), compositor / matte artist (Modules 1 and 4), graphic / poster designer (Module 5, pair with Illustrator), speed & production (Module 6). Depth beats breadth. Point them at the Recipes library for "how do I do X again?"
- 2 **The one idea to keep.** Say: "Work non-destructively, and decide what the viewer should see first. Nearly everything in this course is a variation on those two ideas."
- 3 **Final journal.** Assign the final prompt to finish at home: reread the very first Module 0 entry and answer it from the other side.
- 4 **Celebrate.** Thank them for finishing; courses are easy to start and hard to finish. Applause for every piece.

◆ CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING (WORKBOOK SELF-CHECK)

Answers: **Q1 B)** JPG or PNG in sRGB, keeping the .psd master; **Q2 A)** double-click the Smart Object thumbnail, place the art in the .psb tab, save and close; **Q3 B)** what it is and who it is for, then one decision and why; **Q4 A)** shadows agree on one light, no telltale AI artifacts; **Q5 B)** use the rubric to decide, then ship.

◆ DIFFERENTIATION

- ◆ **Confident presenters:** ask them to show two contexts (a wall frame and a phone) and a process strip, and to name the one grow they already plan to act on.
- ◆ **Anxious presenters:** let them present from their seat, or have you read the statement while they drive the screen. Seat them mid-order, never first or last.

IF THE ROOM ARRIVES BEHIND

PLAN B FOR LEARNERS WHO DID NOT BUILD AT HOME

Some learners will arrive with a plan but little built, or with nothing. Do not let them derail the session. **Scope to one image, one focal point.** Offer a ready-made brief: restore `l21-backup-old-photo.jpg`, or build a product hero shot from `l21-backup-product.jpg` and `l21-backup-backdrop.jpg`. They still present, framed honestly as a "studio sketch," and receive the same critique. Offer a follow-up: email the finished piece within a week for written feedback. If more than half the room is behind, shorten each presentation to 3 minutes and give the saved time to the studio block.

CLOSING THE COURSE

AFTER SESSION 8

Collect delivery files (with permission) for a class gallery. Send each learner their critique notes and the Recipes link. Recap the whole arc: **fix and export one photo → layers and masks → light and color → retouching → compositing → design and type → AI and speed → a finished, presented portfolio piece.** When they started Module 0, that list was a wish list. Now it describes their skills.